

GIACOMO LEOPARDI
POEMS

TRANSLATED, WITH AN INTRODUCTION,

BY

ARTURO VIVANTE

GIACOMO LEOPARDI

POEMS

Giacomo Leopardi, one of the greatest of poets, was born in Recanati in 1798, and died, not yet thirty-nine, in Naples at a time of year when the *ginestra*, or broom, of which he wrote in the poem by that name, was blooming on the slopes of Mount Vesuvius. Few people suffered and rejoiced with his intensity. Love, death, beauty, youth, hope, nature are among his themes. For him the infinite is supremely present. He sees the moon, the stars, the sun, the serene air in their essence.

This book contains a literal verse translation of sixteen of his best known *canti*, accompanied by the Italian text, and an introduction.

Arturo Vivante has written short stories, novels, poems, essays and plays in English and in Italian. His work has been published in books and periodicals in Italy, England and America, especially in *The New Yorker*. He has also translated, from the Italian, Leone Vivante's *Essays on Art and Ontology* for Utah University Press. He teaches literature at Bennington College.

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with the Italian text of the poems

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To my children

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INTRODUCTION

There are books to have near, and Leopardi's *Canti* is assuredly one of them. XIXth-century Italian poetry would be immeasurably poorer without him. Besides the *Canti*, on which his fame mainly rests and which consists of thirty-six poems (in all about 200 pages,) his works include the *Operette Morali*, mostly in dialogue form; the *Zibaldone*, a voluminous diary-like collection or miscellany of observations; the *Pensieri*, or thoughts, which could be considered a distillation of the *Zibaldone*; an annotated edition of Petrarch's *Rhymes* (there are unmistakable echoes of Petrarch in some of his poems,) and the *Paralipomeni*, a satire in verse. His letters are also noteworthy.

He was born in 1798 in the small town of Recanati, in the Marches, a region of central Italy between the Apennine Mountains and the Adriatic Sea. Not till 1822 did he leave his native town, but his thoughts roved over those mountains and that distant sea into the infinite spaces beyond them. His father, Count Monaldo, a man of literary tastes but of narrow political views, and his mother, Adelaide Antici, strict, devout to the point of absurdity, had private tutors for their five children, of whom Giacomo was the eldest. As a child, his joyful voice rang in the halls and garden of his home, but his playful days were soon over. Of a frail constitution and solitary by nature, he spent the best part of his boyhood poring over the books of the huge library that his father had accumulated. He developed a stoop, and for a time his eyesight almost failed him. He became so learned that when he was twelve his tutor said he had nothing left to teach him. He had begun writing poems when ten. Erudite essays followed, some on philology, and one on the history of astronomy. He learned several languages, translated various Greek and Latin authors, and was first published in the *Spettatore* of Milan in 1816. In 1818 his poems drew the attention of the literary critic Pietro Giordani who became his friend and correspondent. Throughout his brief but intense life, Leopardi collected his poems in various editions, first under the title *Canzoni*, then *Versi*, and finally *Canti* — both *canzoni* and *canti* meaning songs in Italian, a word that admirably expresses the nature of his poetry. Santayana likens the experience of reading him to that of a traveller who, with little expectation, goes to a concert in a small town and is astonished to hear a voice purer than any he has ever heard, one that strikes higher notes, reaches greater depths.

Leopardi, despite his conservative upbringing, grew up to be a freethinker. In politics he early espoused the democratic principles of the *Risorgimento*, and in religion he disavowed all dogmas and conventions. As he wrote in "Love and Death," he would never praise or bless the hand that, flailing, tinged itself of his innocent blood. We see, therefore, a rebel spirit, unconventional, brave, in his life and in his death.

He was a very impressionable, sensitive, susceptible youth, and he would easily fall in love. In 1817, Gertrude Cassi Lazzari, his father's cousin, twenty-six, seven years his elder, spent a few days at the Leopardis' palace in Recanati, and Giacomo was struck by her beauty. About her he wrote, among other things, the poem "First Love," and a few touching pages in prose in which he tells that at first he couldn't utter a word, but that the next day, teaching her how to play chess, he began talking to her and made her laugh with little jokes and stories. Soon she was gone, but not from his lovesick mind in which her image lingered, forbidding food and drink and sleep. Even more touching are "To Silvia," often described as the most moving Italian love poem, and "The Dream," both inspired by Teresa Fattorini, the Leopardis' coachman's daughter who died of consumption at an early age. She recurs as Nerina in "The Recollections." With her death, hope died for him, and it is significant that in his poetry hope is connected with love and not with worldly ambitions or with fame. It is also meaningful that differences of wealth and background meant little to him.

In the summer of 1819, feeling restless, isolated, unappreciated, even bored (boredom is a theme, though a minor one, of "Nocturnal Song," and implies dissatisfaction with custom, as Shakespeare calls it, or routine, and is not in any sense a morbid state of mind,) he made plans to flee from Recanati. For a moment, with flight in mind, he saw himself as the embodiment of freedom — freedom's flag flying. But his father thwarted his plans, and, never financially independent, he was forced to stay on. Mortified, he shrank into a state of utter dejection and prostration, from which only his love of poetry and learning saved him. "The Infinite" was written that year.

In 1822 Leopardi finally left Recanati for Rome, where he lived with relatives on Via Condotti, a block away from the house on Piazza di Spagna where Keats had died the year before. Rome, however, disappointed him. Happier were his stays in Milan, Bologna, Florence and Pisa, from which he returned to Recanati more than once. In Bologna he fell in love with Teresa Carniani

Malvezzi, a charming married woman with artistic aspirations, older than he. Leopardi never saw love as profane, always as sacred, and was revolted by any vulgar talk. His love, as Keats's, may never have been consummated, yet it is hard to imagine a more intense one. In Florence, in 1830, he experienced a spiritual rebirth on meeting the beautiful Fanny Targioni Tozzetti, his doctor's wife, who inspired him to write "Aspasia," "The Dominant Thought," "Love and Death," and "To Himself." His love for her, though unrequited, like Keats's love for Fanny Brawne — strange the identical first name, rare in Italian — was, judging from what he says about it and her in "The Dominant Thought," the salient event in his life. He saw in love, and in death, the best things that the world has to offer.

*Of one is goodness born,
born is the highest delight
that in the sea of being is to be found;
the other any pain,
any great evil ends.*

Love and Death, 5.

Though often melancholy, Leopardi could be a spirited and amusing conversationalist, and he made many friends. Not a few — among them Antonio Ranieri, devoted to him to the end — were well aware of his genius. He spent his last years in Naples where he died in 1837, probably of asthma and heart failure (the word *affanno* — literally shortness of breath, gasping, but also pain, travail — frequently recurs in his verses.)

A sense of the infinite — whether awakened by a hedge that while obstructing the view lets the imagination roam, or stirred by the unobscured sight of the stars — pervades Leopardi's thought. The infinite of the heavens is reflected in the infinite of the mind, merges with it and inspires it. The two infinities are really one, and may be expressed by the word "creativity." The mind on which the wonder of creation is not lost partakes of that creation. It begins to fathom the unfathomable. Leopardi's infinite is supremely real.

Leopardi is also the poet of the moon. Here are some of the adjectives he uses for her: *aurea, candida, graziosa, cara, diletta, intatta, vergine, solinga, tacita, silenziosa, muta, pensosa, eterna, immortale, ignuda*, and her ray is *tranquillo, benigno, vezzoso*, as he chants her splendor, her company, her novelty, her pureness,

her mystery, in poem after poem, especially in "To the Moon," "The Solitary Life," "The Evening of the Holiday," "Nocturnal Song of a Wandering Shepherd of Asia," "The Setting of the Moon." Again and again he invokes her, and one is reminded of Keats's *Endymion*, II, 179-182, 223, 225; III, 142-174, 186, and the lines about the moon in *Ode to a Nightingale*, IV, 6,7; Shelley's *The Daemon of the World*, 1, 5, 8; *Queen Mab*, VIII, 148; *Epipsychidion*, 279-285; *Prometheus Unbound*, IV, 495-498; *The Waning Moon*; *To the Moon*; and Wordsworth's *Composed among the Ruins of a Castle in North Wales*, 4, 5-8. Indeed it has been given to only a few poets to write about the moon — its subtle quality, its fairy power, its essence — with the spiritual lightness required.

There is a remarkable resemblance between Leopardi, and Shelley and Keats, who were born within a few years of each other (Shelley in 1792, Keats in 1795, Leopardi in 1798,) who died young, and were so sensitive to beauty and the charm of women. Similar accents are found not only as regards the moon, but also in connection with the infinite of space, time, eternity, cf. Leopardi's "The Infinite;" "Nocturnal Song," 72; and the following lines from "The Broom," 175-184:

*...and when I look
at those even more endlessly remote
nodes almost of stars
that to us seem like mist, to which not man
and not the stars alone, but all in one, our stars,
infinite in number and in size,
together with the golden sun,
are either unknown, or appear even as
they to earth, a point
of nebulous light;...*

with Shelley's *Prometheus Unbound*, I, 416-421:

*Yet pause, and plunge
Into Eternity, where recorded time,
Even all that we imagine, age on age,
Seems but a point, and the reluctant mind
Flags wearily in its unending flight,
Till it sink, dizzy, blind, lost, shelterless...*

and Keats's *Sonnet, When I have fears...*

*When I behold, upon the night's starr'd face,
Huge cloudy symbols of a high romance,...*

In Leopardi's poetry, especially in "The Solitary Sparrow," "To Silvia," "Nocturnal Song," "The Calm after the Storm," the serene sky attains, as in Shelley, (*Epipsychidion*, 506,) an intense reality. As regards death, Keats says in *The Ode to a Nightingale*, VI, 1-3:

*Darkling I listen; and for many a time
I have been half in love with easeful Death,
Call'd him soft names in many a mused rhyme,...*

and Leopardi, in "The Recollections," 106:

*And already in youth's first tumult
of contentments, anguishes, desire,
death I called many times,...*

Much has been written about Leopardi's pessimism. But, no less than Thomas Hardy, he would have resented the label. His poetry, if not his prose, is an affirmation of values. The beauty of love, of youth with its hopes, of the serene sky, of the moon, of the stars, of the fragrant hills, of "the golden paths and orchards," is never lost sight of. Nor, it is quite true, is the beauty of death. But, since death is inevitable and something which we must all experience, praise of it can't be taken as a sign of pessimism, negativism, or cynicism. Death must be seen as a part of life, its last experience, in fact a proof of life — since what cannot die doesn't live, and life could be defined as the ability to die. On the other hand, the horror of factual death, as opposed to the thought of death, is powerfully expressed in the poem "On The Portrait of a Beautiful Woman." There are indeed moments of utter despair and gloom in his poetry, as in part of "Nocturnal Song," and "To Himself," written after he had lost all hope of his love for Fanny ever being returned. But these are more than made up for by such lines as the following in "The Dominant Thought" (love):

*To reap your joys, sweet thought,
tasting human woes,
and sustaining for many years
this mortal life, was not unworthy;
and again, with such a goal in view,*

*even as I am, an expert in our ills,
its course I would renew.*

Few people, I think, would be willing to repeat their life just as it was for the sake of one bright moment. It takes a certain faith in life, optimism, to do that. One who intensely misses youth, joy, love, doesn't deny those values but glorifies them, and cannot properly be called a pessimist. In decrying old age, as Shakespeare in *Sonnet 73* (*That time of year thou mayst in me behold,*) he is implicitly extolling youth. Likewise, his portrayal of nature as a hard, hostile demiurge in "The Broom" is in part belied, or at least mellowed, by the beauty of his landscapes in that same poem and elsewhere.

There are, in Leopardi's poetry, passages that savor of the less attractive aspects of romanticism — in certain parts of "The Dominant Thought," for instance, where he calls love an illusion or deception (and again one is reminded of the "deceiving elf" at the end of Keat's *Ode to a Nightingale*.) But such doubts are only natural for a poet, make the poet in fact more of a poet, and do not in the least weaken Leopardi's belief in the reality of love, so strongly affirmed in most of the very same poem, in "Love and Death" and elsewhere.

Leopardi is most universal where he is most intimate. Intimacy is more revealing and truer than any generalization. Also, as in other poets, the clearest verses are the best — clarity and beauty go hand in hand. That which is best expressed, in art and in science, is truest. The poems struck in the secrecy of his own experience, like "The Recollections," or the passage quoted above from "The Broom," are, I think, more significant and on a higher lyrical plane than the polemical passages in the latter poem. Well taken though his moral and social points are, and though they have recently been paid a great deal of attention by some pragmatic literary critics, they seem to me to belong to a more prosaic and less original thought.

The sixteen poems in this book are among his best known. Leopardi was quite innovative in his meter. Most of his poems, and all the ones included here, are written in free verse with only an occasional rhyme. The rhymes appear felicitously, spontaneously, like cloudlets in an azure sky, to lend a certain spiritual lightness to the verses. He went through many revisions of his work. Often he used simple words, and quite frequently words that have more than one meaning, e.g. the word *vago*, which can mean vague, fair, or wandering, as well as loving, desirous. He

was also fond of using words in their earliest, original, etymological sense, e.g. *esulta*, leaps ("The Solitary Life," 2) and *lenta*, lithe ("The Broom," 297) are Latin forms. In these literal verse translations, I have tried to be as faithful as I could to the original, knowing well that even a slight change in the order of words in a line of poetry — and translation is a far more drastic change — is going to reduce the beauty and truth of that line. Yet I have persevered, sustained by the conviction that beauty of expression has a certain inherent resistance which won't keep it from being reduced and even spoiled by translation, but will save it from being destroyed altogether. The Venus de Milo, reduced to a fraction of its size and molded in plastic, is still an arresting sight.

Il passero solitario

D'in su la vetta della torre antica, passero solitario, alla campagna cantando vai finché non more il giorno; ed erra l'armonia per questa valle.	
Primavera dintorno	5
brilla nell'aria, e per li campi esulta, sì ch'a mirarla intenerisce il core.	
Odi greggi belar, muggire armenti; gli altri augelli contenti, a gara insieme per lo libero ciel fan mille giri, pur festeggiando il lor tempo migliore:	10
tu pensoso in disparte il tutto miri; non compagni, non voli, non ti cal d'allegria, schivi gli spassi; canti, e così trapassi	15
dell'anno e di tua vita il più bel fiore.	
Oimè, quanto somiglia al tuo costume il mio! Sollazzo e riso, della novella età dolce famiglia, e te german di giovinezza, amore,	20
sospiro acerbo de' provetti giorni, non curo, io non so come; anzi da loro quasi fuggo lontano; quasi romito, e strano	
al mio loco natio, passo del viver mio la primavera.	25
Questo giorno ch'omai cede alla sera, festeggiar si costuma al nostro borgo.	
Odi per lo sereno un suon di squilla, odi spesso un tonar di ferree canne, che rimbomba lontan di villa in villa.	30
Tutta vestita a festa la gioventù del loco lascia le case, e per le vie si spande; e mira ed è mirata, e in cor s'allegra.	
Io solitario in questa rimota parte alla campagna uscendo, ogni diletto e gioco indugio in altro tempo: e intanto il guardo	35

The solitary sparrow

From the ancient tower's summit
to the country, solitary sparrow,
singing you go until the daylight dies;
and the harmony wanders through this vale.
Spring all around
shines in the air, and through the fields exults,
so that the heart softens at the sight.
You hear flocks bleat, herds low;
glad the other birds together vye
to make a thousand turns in the free sky,
their best time hailing too.
You, pensive and aloof, gaze on it all;
no company, no flights,
gaiety you neglect, you shun all play:
you sing and so pass by
of the year and of your life the fairest flower.

Ah me, how close
to your custom is mine! Solace and laughter,
sweet kin of early years,
and you, love, brother of youth,
bitter sigh of riper days,
I heed not, I know not why; indeed from them
I almost flee afar;
almost a hermit, and a stranger
to my birthplace,
I pass the springtime of my life.
This day which yields to evening now,
is kept as a holiday in this town.
You hear through the serene air a sound of bells,
often you hear the thunder of a gun
booming far away from farm to farm.
All dressed in their best clothes
the local youth
leave their homes, and pour into the streets,
admiring and admired, and in their hearts rejoicing.
I solitary in this
remote part going out into the country,
every delight and play
delay to another time: and meanwhile my gaze

steso nell'aria aprica 40
mi fere il Sol che tra lontani monti,
dopo il giorno sereno,
cadendo si dilegua, e par che dica
che la beata gioventù vien meno.

Tu, solingo augellin, venuto a sera 45
del viver che daranno a te le stelle,
certo del tuo costume
non ti dorrai; che di natura è frutto
ogni vostra vaghezza.

A me, se di vecchiezza 50
la detestata soglia
evitar non impetro,
quando muti questi occhi all'altrui core,
e lor fia vòto il mondo, e il dì futuro
del dì presente più noioso e tetro, 55
che parrà di tal voglia?

che di quest'anni miei? che di me stesso?
Ahi pentirommi, e spesso,
ma sconsolato, volgerommi indietro.

L'infinito

Sempre caro mi fu quest'ermo colle,
e questa siepe, che da tanta parte
dell'ultimo orizzonte il guardo esclude.
Ma sedendo e mirando, interminati
spazi di là da quella, e sovrumani 5
silenzi, e profondissima quiete
io nel pensier mi fingo; ove per poco
il cor non si spaura. E come il vento
odo stormir tra queste piante, io quello
infinito silenzio a questa voce 10
vo comparando: e mi sovvien l'eterno,
e le morte stagioni, e la presente
e viva, e il suon di lei. Così tra questa
immensità s'annega il pensier mio:
e il naufragar m'è dolce in questo mare. 15

fixed in the bright air
is struck by the Sun which,
after the serene day,
setting over distant mountains,
disappears, and seems to say
that blissful youth gives way.

You, lonely little bird, having come to the evening
of the life that the stars will give to you,
certainly won't regret your custom; for fruit of nature is
every vagary of yours.

To me — should I fail to avoid
the detested threshold of old age,
when mute these eyes to another's heart,
and empty the world for them shall become, and future day
than present day more tedious and more bleak —
what will such craving seem?
what these years of mine? what I myself?
Ah, I will repent, and often,
but disconsolate, turn back.

The infinite

Always dear to me was this solitary hill,
and this hedge, that excludes so great a part
of the farthest horizon from my sight.

But sitting and gazing, boundless
spaces beyond it, and superhuman
silences, and deepest quiet

I envision in my mind; where almost
awed is the heart. And as the wind
I hear sighing through these plants, I that
infinite silence to this voice

go comparing: and I remember eternity,
and the dead seasons, and the present
and live one, and its sound. So in this
immensity my thought is drowned:
and sweet to me is shipwreck in this sea.

La sera del dì di festa

Dolce e chiara è la notte e senza vento,
e queta sovra i tetti e in mezzo agli orti
posa la luna, e di lontan rivela
serena ogni montagna. O donna mia,
già tace ogni sentiero, e pei balconi
rara traluce la notturna lampa:
tu dormi, che t'accolse agevol sonno
nelle tue chete stanze; e non ti morde
cura nessuna; e già non sai né pensi
quanta piaga m'apristi in mezzo al petto.
Tu dormi: io questo ciel, che sì benigno
appare in vista, a salutar m'affaccio,
e l'antica natura onnipossente,
che mi fece all'affanno. A te la speme
nego, mi disse, anche la speme; e d'altro
non brillin gli occhi tuoi se non di pianto.
Questo dì fu solenne: or da' trastulli
prendi riposo; e forse ti rimembra
in sogno a quanti oggi piacesti, e quanti
piacquero a te: non io, non già ch'io spero,
al pensier ti ricorro. Intanto io chieggo
quanto a viver mi resti, e qui per terra
mi getto, e grido, e fremo. Oh giorni orrendi
in così verde etate! Ahi, per la via
odo non lunge il solitario canto
dell'artigian, che riede a tarda notte,
dopo i sollazzi, al suo povero ostello;
e fieramente mi si stringe il core,
a pensar come tutto al mondo passa,
e quasi orma non lascia. Ecco è fuggito
il dì festivo, ed al festivo il giorno
volgar succede, e se ne porta il tempo
ogni umano accidente. Or dov'è il suono
di que' popoli antichi? or dov'è il grido
de' nostri avi famosi, e il grande impero
di quella Roma, e l'armi, e il fragorio
che n'andò per la terra e l'oceano?
Tutto è pace e silenzio, e tutto posa
il mondo, e più di lor non si ragiona.
Nella mia prima età, quando s'aspetta

The evening of the holiday

Sweet and clear is the night and without wind,
and quiet over the roofs and mid the orchards
lingers the moon, and from afar reveals
serene each mountain. O woman mine,
already quiet is each path, and through the windows
gleams a rare nocturnal lamp:
you sleep, whom easeful slumber welcomed
in your quiet rooms; and no care whatever
grips you; nor do you know or wonder
what wound you opened amid my breast.
You sleep: this sky which appears so benign
to the sight, I lean to greet,
and ancient nature almighty,
that created me to suffer. Hope
I deny you, she said, even hope, and of naught
may your eyes shine other than tears.
Today was a holiday: now from entertainment
you take rest; and perhaps you recall
in a dream how many today liked you, and how many
you liked: not I, I'm beyond hoping,
recur in your thought. Meanwhile I ask
how long I've left to live, and here on the ground
I throw myself, and cry, and shudder. Oh horrid days
at such a verdant age! Ah, along the road
I hear not far away the solitary song
of a workman, who late at night returns,
after play, to his poor home;
and it fiercely wrings my heart
to think how everything in the world passes,
and almost leaves no trace. Here now the festive day
has fled, and upon the festive
the workday follows, and time bears
every human happening away. Now where is the sound
of those ancient people? where is the cry
of our famous ancestors, and the great empire
of that Rome, and the arms, and the din
that went through earth and ocean from it?
All is silence and peace, and the whole
world rests, and we talk no more about them.
In my early age, longingly

bramosamente il dì festivo, or poscia
ch'egli era spento, io doloroso, in veglia,
premea le piume; ed alla tarda notte
un canto che s'udia per li sentieri
lontanando morire a poco a poco,
già similmente mi stringeva il core.

45

Alla luna

O graziosa luna, io mi rammento
che, or volge l'anno, sovra questo colle
io venia pien d'angoscia a rimirarti:
e tu pendevi allor su quella selva
siccome or fai, che tutta la rischiari.
Ma nebuloso e tremulo dal pianto
che mi sorgea sul ciglio, alle mie luci
il tuo volto apparìa, che travagliosa
era mia vita: ed è, né cangia stile,
o mia diletta luna. E pur mi giova
la ricordanza, e il noverar l'etate
del mio dolore. Oh come grato occorre
nel tempo giovanil, quando ancor lungo
la speme e breve ha la memoria il corso,
il rimembrar delle passate cose,
ancor che triste, e che l'affanno duri!

5

10

15

for the holiday I would wait, and when
it was over, sad and wakeful,
I would press the pillow; and late at night
a song which could be heard recede
and die over the paths little by little,
even as now would clench my heart.

To the moon

O graceful moon, I remember,
now turns a year, upon this hill
I would come full of anguish to look at you:
and you hung over that wood
as now you do, lighting it all.
But hazy and tremulous for the tears
rising at my lashes, to my eyes
your visage seemed, for toilsome
was my life: and is, nor changes style,
o my beloved moon. And yet it helps me
to remember, and to count the age
of my pain. Oh how welcome
in the time of youth, while yet memory a short
and hope a long course holds,
is the remembrance of things past,
even though sad, and though the travail last!

La vita solitaria

La mattutina pioggia, allor che l'ale
battendo esulta nella chiusa stanza
la gallinella, ed al balcon s'affaccia
l'abitator de' campi, e il Sol che nasce
i suoi tremuli rai fra le cadenti
5 stille saetta, alla capanna mia
dolcemente picchiando, mi risveglia;
e sorgo, e i lievi nugoletti, e il primo
degli augelli susurro, e l'aura fresca,
e le ridenti piagge benedico: 10
poiché voi, cittadine infauste mura,
vidi e conobbi assai, là dove segue
odio al dolor compagno; e doloroso
io vivo, e tal morrò, deh tosto! Alcune
benché scarsa pietà pur mi dimostra 15
natura in questi lochi, un giorno oh quanto
verso me più cortese! E tu pur volgi
dai miseri lo sguardo; e tu, sdegnando
le sciagure e gli affanni, alla reina
felicità servi, o natura. In cielo, 20
in terra amico agl'infelici alcuno
e rifugio non resta altro che il ferro.

Talor m'assido in solitaria parte,
sopra un rialto, al margine d'un lago
di taciturne piante incoronato. 25
Ivi, quando il meriggio in ciel si volge,
la sua tranquilla imago il Sol dipinge,
ed erba o foglia non si crolla al vento,
e non onda incresparsi, e non cicala
strider, né batter penna augello in ramo, 30
né farfalla ronzar, né voce o moto
da presso né da lunge odi né vedi.
Tien quelle rive altissima quiete;
ond'io quasi me stesso e il mondo obbligo
sedendo immoto; e già mi par che sciolte 35
giaccian le membra mie, né spirito o senso,
più le commova, e lor quiete antica
co' silenzi del loco si confonda.

The solitary life

The morning rain — when the little hen
leaps in her closed room
flapping her wings, and out his window leans
the country dweller, and the rising Sun
its tremulous rays through falling
droplets darts — on my cottage
sweetly beating wakes me;
and I rise and bless the faint cloudlets,
and the first twitter of birds,
and the fresh air and smiling slopes:
for I saw you and knew you well enough,
unhappy city walls, where
hatred follows sorrow as a companion; and sorry
I live, and such shall die, pray soon! Some
though scant pity nature yet
shows me in these places, once oh how much
kindlier to me! And you too turn
your glance away from the wretched; you too, disdaining
disasters and griefs, queenly
happiness serve, o nature. In the sky,
on earth for the unhappy no friend
or refuge is left other than steel.

At times I sit in a solitary place,
on a height, at the margin of a lake
wreathed by taciturn plants.
There, when it turns noon in the sky,
the Sun depicts its tranquil image,
and neither grass nor leaf tremble in the wind,
nor wave ripple, nor cicada
chirp, nor beat its wings bird on a branch,
nor butterfly whirl, nor voice or motion
from near or from far you hear or see.
Deepest quiet holds those shores;
where I, sitting still, myself and the world
almost forget; and it seems to me that loose
already lie my limbs, that no spirit or sense
moves them anymore, and that their ancient quietness
with the place's silences is mingled.

Love, love, far away did you flee
from my breast, which was so warm one day,
or rather, burning. With its cold hand
disaster clenched it, and to ice it has turned
in my years' bloom. I remember the time
when you descended in my breast. It was that sweet
and irrevocable time, when to the youthful gaze
this unhappy scene of the world is disclosed,
and it smiles to him in the semblance
of paradise. The boy's heart
with virgin hope and desire
leaps in his breast; and already
for this life's task the wretched mortal
readies himself as for a dance or game.
But no sooner, love, I became aware of you
than fate had already broken my life, and for these eyes
naught other was there left than crying always.
Yet if sometimes along bright slopes,
upon the silent dawn or when the roofs
and hills and fields shine in the sun,
I meet the visage of a pretty girl;
or when at times in the placid quiet
of a summer night, staying my
wandering step opposite a farmhouse,
I contemplate the solitary land,
and hear ringing in the lonely rooms
the keen song of a girl
working late into the night,
this stony heart of mine is set throbbing: ah, but soon
it returns to its iron-like stupor; for alien
has become every blissful emotion to my breast.

O dear moon, to whose tranquil ray
dance the hares in the woods; and sorry
in the morning is the hunter, finding
the footprints intricate and false, misled
by varied error from their lairs; hail o benign
queen of the nights. Irksome descends
your ray through brambles and knolls or within
deserted buildings, on the steel blade
of the pale robber who with cocked ear
the rumble of wheels and of horses
observes from afar or the trample of footsteps

su la tacita via; poscia improvviso col suon dell'armi e con la rauca voce e col funereo ceffo il core agghiaccia al passegger, cui semivivo e nudo lascia in breve tra'sassi. Infesto occorre	85
per le contrade cittadine il bianco tuo lume al drudo vil, che degli alberghi va radendo le mura e la secreta ombra seguendo, e resta, e si spaura delle ardenti lucerne e degli aperti balconi. Infesto alle malvage menti,	90
a me sempre benigno il tuo cospetto sarà per queste piagge, ove non altro che lieti colli e spaziosi campi m'apri alla vista. Ed ancor io soleva,	95
bench'innocente io fossi, il tuo vezzoso raggio accusar negli abitati lochi, quand'ei m'offriva al guardo umano, e quando scopriva umani aspetti al guardo mio.	100
Or sempre loderollo, o ch'io ti miri veleggiar tra le nubi, o che serena dominatrice dell'etereo campo, questa flebil riguardi umana sede. Me spesso rivedrai solingo e muto errar pe' boschi e per le verdi rive,	105
o seder sovra l'erbe, assai contento se core e lena a sospirar m'avanza.	

A Silvia

Silvia, rimembri ancora quel tempo della tua vita mortale, quando beltà splendea negli occhi tuoi ridenti e fuggitivi, e tu, lieta e pensosa, il limitare di gioventù salivi?	5
--	---

Sonavan le quiete
stanze, e le vie dintorno,

on the silent road; then suddenly
with sound of arms and with his gruff voice
and with his ghastly mask he chills
the passenger's heart, whom half-alive and naked
shortly he leaves on the stones. Irksome appears
along city blocks your white light
to the vile lecher, who goes grazing
the walls of dwellings and follows any concealing
shadow, and pauses, and is scared
of burning lamps and open windows.
Irksome to evil minds,
to me ever benign your presence
will be over these slopes, where nothing other
than happy hills and spacious fields
you disclose to my sight. And even I,
though innocent I was, used to blame
your playful ray in inhabited places,
when it exposed me to the human sight, and when
it disclosed human features to my sight.
Now always I shall praise it, whether I see you
sailing through the clouds, or when serene
mistress of the ethereal field,
you watch over this plaintive home of man.
Me often you will see alone and quiet
roaming through the woods and the green shores,
or sitting on the grass, quite content
if I am left enough heart and breath with which to sigh.

To Silvia

Silvia, do you still remember
that time of your mortal life,
when beauty shone
in your laughing, fleeting eyes,
and you, pensive and glad, ascended
to the threshold of your youth?

Rang the quiet
rooms, and the streets around,

al tuo perpetuo canto, allor che all'opre femminili intenta sedevi, assai contenta di quel vago avvenir che in mente avevi. Era il maggio odoroso: e tu solevi così menare il giorno.	10
Io gli studi leggiadri talor lasciando e le sudate carte, ove il tempo mio primo e di me si spendea la miglior parte, d'in su i veroni del paterno ostello porgea gli orecchi al suon della tua voce ed alla man veloce che percorrea la faticosa tela. Mirava il ciel sereno, le vie dorate e gli orti, e quinci il mar da lungi, e quindi il monte.	15 20
Lingua mortal non dice quel ch'io sentiva in seno.	25
Che pensieri soavi, che speranze, che cori, o Silvia mia! Quale allor ci apparia la vita umana e il fato!	30
Quando sovviemmi di cotanta speme, un affetto mi preme acerbo e sconsolato, e tornami a doler di mia sventura.	35
O natura, o natura, perché non rendi poi quel che prometti allor? perché di tanto inganni i figli tuoi?	
Tu pria che l'erbe inaridisse il verno, da chiuso morbo combattuta e vinta, perivi, o tenerella. E non vedevi il fior degli anni tuoi; non ti molceva il core la dolce lode or delle negre chiome, or degli sguardi innamorati e schivi; né teco le compagne ai dì festivi ragionavan d'amore.	40 45

with your perpetual song,
while on girlish work intent
you sat, well content
with that bright future which you had in mind.
It was the fragrant May: and so
you used to lead the day.

I my pleasant studies
leaving sometimes and my belabored papers,
on which my early age
and the best part of me were spent,
from the balconies of my paternal home
to the sound of your voice would lend my ears,
and to the quick hand racing
over the tiring loom.
I viewed the serene sky,
the golden lanes and orchards,
and on this side the sea, on that the mountain.
Mortal tongue does not say
what in my breast I felt.

What tender thoughts,
what hopes, what hearts, o Silvia mine!
How human life and fate
seemed to us then!
When I remember so much hope,
an affection besets me
bitter and forlorn,
and for my plight again I turn to mourn.
O nature, o nature,
why do you not then deliver
what you promise? why do you deceive
your children of so much?

You, before winter had withered the grass,
by a hidden sickness struck and overcome,
perished, o my little tender one. Nor would you see
the flowering of your years;
praise now of your black hair,
now of your winning, bashful eyes
would not blandish your heart;
nor would your friends on festive days
talk to you of love.

Anche peria fra poco	
la speranza mia dolce: agli anni miei	50
anche negaro i fati	
la giovanezza. Ahi come,	
come passata sei,	
cara compagna dell'età mia nova,	
mia lacrimata speme!	55
Questo è quel mondo? questi	
i diletti, l'amor, l'opre, gli eventi	
onde cotanto ragionammo insieme?	
questa la sorte dell'umane genti?	
All'apparir del vero	60
tu, misera, cadesti: e con la mano	
la fredda morte ed una tomba ignuda	
mostravi di lontano.	

Le ricordanze

Vaghe stelle dell'Orsa, io non credea	
tornare ancor per uso a contemplarvi	
sul paterno giardino scintillanti,	
e ragionar con voi dalle finestre	
di questo albergo ove abitai fanciullo,	5
e delle gioie mie vidi la fine.	
Quante immagini un tempo, e quante fole	
creommi nel pensier l'aspetto vostro	
e delle luci a voi compagne! allora	
che, tacito, seduto in verde zolla,	10
delle sere io solea passar gran parte	
mirando il cielo, ed ascoltando il canto	
della rana rimota alla campagna!	
E la lucciola errava appo le siepi	
e in su l'aiuole, susurrando al vento	15
i viali odorati, ed i cipressi	
là nella selva; e sotto al patrio tetto	
sonavan voci alterne, e le tranquille	
opre de' servi. E che pensieri immensi,	
che dolci sogni mi spirò la vista	20
di quel lontano mar, quei monti azzurri,	

Also perished soon
my sweet hope: to my years
the fates denied even
youth. Ah how,
how you have passed,
dear companion of my early age,
my tearful hope!
Is this that world? These
the delights, the love, the deeds, the events
we talked of together for so long?
This the lot of mankind?
At the appearing of truth
you, wretched, fell: and with your hand
cold death and a bare tomb
you showed from far away.

The recollections

Lovely stars of the Bear, I did not think
I would return again to contemplate you
glittering on the garden of my home,
and to be talking with you from the windows
of this abode where as a child I dwelt,
and of my joys saw the end.
How many images once, how many fancies
the sight of you and your companion lights
created in my thoughts! when,
silent, sitting on the lawn,
much of the evening I would pass
watching the sky, and listening to the song
of the frog remote out in the country!
And the firefly wandered by hedges
and on flower beds, while the odorous drives
murmured in the wind, and the cypresses
there in the wood, and under my father's roof
alternate voices sounded, and the servants'
tranquil tasks. And what immense thoughts,
what sweet dreams inspired me the sight
of that far sea, those azure mountains,

che di qua scopro, e che varcare un giorno
io mi pensava, arcani mondi, arcana
felicità fingendo al viver mio!
ignaro del mio fato, e quante volte
questa mia vita dolorosa e nuda
volentier con la morte avrei cangiato. 25

Né mi diceva il cor che l'età verde
sarei dannato a consumare in questo
natio borgo selvaggio, intra una gente 30
zotica, vil; cui nomi strani, e spesso
argomento di riso e di trastullo,
son dottrina e saper; che m'odia e fugge,
per invidia non già, che non mi tiene
maggior di sé, ma perché tale estima 35
ch'io mi tenga in cor mio, sebben di fuori
a persona giammai non ne fo segno.
Qui passo gli anni, abbandonato, occulto,
senz'amor, senza vita; ed aspro a forza
tra lo stuol de' malevoli divengo: 40
qui di pietà mi spoglio e di virtùdi,
e sprezzator degli uomini mi rendo,
per la greggia ch'ho appresso: e intanto vola
il caro tempo giovanil; più caro
che la fama e l'allor, più che la pura 45
luce del giorno, e lo spirar: ti perdo
senza un diletto, inutilmente, in questo
soggiorno disumano, intra gli affanni,
o dell'arida vita unico fiore.

Viene il vento recando il suon dell'ora 50
dalla torre del borgo. Era conforto
questo suon, mi rimembra, alle mie notti,
quando fanciullo, nella buia stanza,
per assidui terrori io vigilava,
sospirando il mattin. Qui non è cosa 55
ch'io vegga o senta, onde un'immagin dentro
non torni, e un dolce rimembrar non sorga.
Dolce per sé; ma con dolor sottentra
il pensier del presente, un van desio
del passato, ancor tristo, e il dire: io fui. 60
Quella loggia colà, volta agli estremi
raggi del dì; queste dipinte mura,

which from here I descry, and which I thought
of crossing some day, arcane worlds, arcane
happiness fancying for my life!
unaware of my fate, and how many times
this painful and bare life of mine
willingly with death I would have changed.

Nor did my heart tell me my green age
I would be damned to waste in this
my savage town, among a coarse, vile
people: for whom strange nouns, and often
occasion for laughter and derision,
are learning and knowledge; who hate me and shun me,
oh, not for envy, for they hold me
no greater than themselves, but because such they deem
that I hold myself in my heart, though to no one
do I ever point it out.

Here I pass the years, abandoned, ignored,
without love, without life, and perforce bitter
among the throng of the malevolent become:
here pity and virtue I doff,
and of men grow contemptuous,
for the herd that's around me: and meanwhile flies
the dear time of youth; dearer
than fame and laurel, or the pure
light of day, and breath of air: I lose you
without one delight, uselessly, in this
inhuman sojourn, among travails,
o of arid life sole flower.

The wind wafts the sound that strikes the hour
from the tower of the town. This sound, I remember,
was a comfort to my nights,
when as a child, in the dark room,
through unremitting terrors I lay awake,
sighing for morning. Here there is nothing
that I see or hear, from which an image within
will not return, or a sweet remembering spring forth.
Sweet in itself; but with pain
the thought of the present finds its way, a vain longing
for the past, even though sad, and saying: I was.
That loggia there, looking on the last
rays of the day; these frescoed walls,

quei figurati armenti, e il Sol che nasce
 su romita campagna, agli ozi miei
 porser mille dilette allor che al fianco
 m'era, parlando, il mio possente errore
 sempre, ov'io fossi. In queste sale antiche,
 al chiaror delle nevi, intorno a queste
 ampie finestre sibilando il vento,
 rimbombano i sollazzi e le festose
 mie voci al tempo che l'acerbo, indegno
 mistero delle cose a noi si mostra
 pien di dolcezza; indelibata, intera
 il garzoncel, come inesperto amante,
 la sua vita ingannevole vagheggia,
 e celeste beltà fingendo ammira.

65

70

75

O speranze, speranze; ameni inganni
 della mia prima età! sempre, parlando,
 ritorno a voi; che per andar di tempo,
 per variar d'affetti e di pensieri,
 obbliarvi non so. Fantasma, intendo,
 son la gloria e l'onor; dilette e beni
 mero desio; non ha la vita un frutto,
 inutile miseria. E sebben vòti
 son gli anni miei, sebben deserto, oscuro
 il mio stato mortal, poco mi toglie
 la fortuna, ben veggo. Ahi, ma qualvolta
 a voi ripenso, o mie speranze antiche,
 ed a quel caro immaginar mio primo;
 indi riguardo il viver mio sì vile
 e sì dolente, e che la morte è quello
 che di cotanta speme oggi m'avanza;
 sento serrarmi il cor, sento ch'al tutto
 consolarmi non so del mio destino.
 E quando pur questa invocata morte
 sarammi allato, e sarà giunto il fine
 della sventura mia; quando la terra
 mi fia straniera valle, e dal mio sguardo
 fuggirà l'avvenir; di voi per certo
 risovverrammi; e quell'imago ancora
 sospirar mi farà, farammi acerbo
 l'esser vissuto indarno, e la dolcezza
 del dì fatal tempererà d'affanno.

80

85

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95

100

those pictured herds, and the Sun rising
on the solitary fields, to my idle hours
lent a thousand delights when by my side,
talking to me, was my potent illusion
always, wherever I might be. In these ancient halls,
in the snows' light, while the wind
whistled around these ample windows,
echoed my games and playful voice
at the time when the bitter, unworthy
mystery of things to us appears
full of sweetness. The boy, like an inexperienced lover,
feigning celestial beauty,
cherishes and fancies
his beguiling life, unravished, whole.

O hopes, hopes, pleasant illusions
of my early age! ever, speaking,
I return to you; for though time passes,
though affections and thoughts vary,
I can't forget you. Phantoms, I say,
are glory and honor; delights and wealth
mere whims; life has not a fruit,
useless misery. And though empty
are my years, though deserted, obscure
my mortal state, fortune takes
but little away from me, well I see. Ah, but whenever
I think of you again, o my hopes of long ago,
and of those first dear imaginings of mine,
then review my living so vile
and painful, and see that death is what today
is left to me of so much hope;
I feel a wringing at my heart, I feel that I don't know
how to console myself altogether of my fate.
And when at last this invoked death
will be at my side, and reached will be the end
of my sad plight; when the earth
will become for me an alien valley, and from my eyes
the future will flee; you for sure
I'll remember; and that image again
will make me sigh, will make me bitter
to have lived in vain, and the sweetness
of the fatal day will be tempered by distress.

E già nel primo giovanil tumulto
 di contenti, d'angosce e di desio, 105
 morte chiamai più volte, e lungamente
 mi sedetti colà su la fontana
 pensoso di cessar dentro quell'acque
 la speme e il dolor mio. Poscia, per cieco
 malor, condotto della vita in forse, 110
 piansi la bella giovinezza, e il fiore
 de' miei poveri dì, che sì per tempo
 cadeva: e spesso all'ore tarde, assiso
 sul conscio letto, dolorosamente
 alla fioca lucerna poetando, 115
 lamentai co' silenzi e con la notte
 il fuggitivo spirto, ed a me stesso
 in sul languir cantai funereo canto.

Chi rimembrar vi può senza sospiri,
 o primo entrar di giovinezza, o giorni 120
 vezzosi, inenarrabili, allor quando
 al rapito mortal primieramente
 sorridon le donzelle; a gara intorno
 ogni cosa sorride; invidia tace,
 non desta ancora ovver benigna; e quasi 125
 (inusitata meraviglia!) il mondo
 la destra soccorrevole gli porge,
 scusa gli errori suoi, festeggia il novo
 suo venir nella vita, ed inchinando
 mostra che per signor l'accolga e chiami? 130
 Fugaci giorni! a somigliar d'un lampo
 son dileguati. E qual mortale ignaro
 di sventura esser può, se a lui già scorsa
 quella vaga stagion, se il suo buon tempo,
 se giovinezza, ahì giovinezza, è spenta? 135

O Nerina! e di te forse non odo
 questi luoghi parlar? caduta forse
 dal mio pensier sei tu? Dove sei gita,
 che qui sola di te la ricordanza
 trovo, dolcezza mia? Più non ti vede 140
 questa Terra natal: quella finestra,
 ond'eri usata favellarmi, ed onde
 mesto riluce delle stelle il raggio,
 è deserta. Ove sei, che più non odo

And already in youth's first tumult
of contentments, anguishes, desire,
death I called many times, and long
I sat there by the fountain
thinking to end under those waters
my hope and sorrow. Then led
by a dark affliction to the brink of life,
I bewailed beautiful youth, and the flower
of my poor days, which so soon
fell: and often in late hours, seated
on the knowing bed, dolorously
poetizing by the feeble lamp,
I lamented with the silences and with the night
the fugitive spirit, and to myself
in languishing I sang funereal chant.

Who can remember you without a sigh,
o first entering of youth, o graceful,
unrecountable days, when
to the enraptured mortal first
girls smile; everything around
vies to smile; envy is silent,
unawakened yet or else benign; and almost
(unaccustomed marvel!) the world
lends him a helping hand,
pardons his errors, hails his new
advent into life, and bowing
seems to welcome him and treat him as a master?
Fleeting days! even as lightning
they have vanished. And what mortal can be
unaware of misfortune, if that fair
season is over, if his good time,
if youth, ay youth, is spent?

O Nerina! and of you perhaps do I not hear
these places speak? fallen perhaps
are you from my thoughts? Where have you gone,
that here of you I find only the remembrance,
my sweet one? This native Earth
sees you no more: that window,
from which you used to talk to me, and through which
glitter the wan rays of the stars
is deserted. Where are you, that no longer I hear

la tua voce sonar, siccome un giorno, 145
 quando soleva ogni lontano accento
 del labbro tuo, ch'a me giungesse, il volto
 scolorarmi? Altro tempo. I giorni tuoi
 furo, mio dolce amor. Passasti. Ad altri
 il passar per la terra oggi è sortito, 150
 e l'abitar questi odorati colli.
 Ma rapida passasti; e come un sogno
 fu la tua vita. Ivi danzando; in fronte
 la gioia ti splendea, splendea negli occhi
 quel confidente immaginar, quel lume 155
 di gioventù, quando spegneali il fato,
 e giacevi. Ahi Nerina! In cor mi regna
 l'antico amor. Se a feste anco talvolta,
 se a radunanze io movo, infra me stesso
 dico: o Nerina, a radunanze, a feste 160
 tu non ti acconci più, tu più non movi.
 Se torna maggio, e ramoscelli e suoni
 van gli amanti recando alle fanciulle,
 dico: Nerina mia, per te non torna
 primavera giammai, non torna amore. 165
 Ogni giorno sereno, ogni fiorita
 spiaggia ch'io miro, ogni goder ch'io sento,
 dico: Nerina or più non gode; i campi,
 l'aria non mira. Ahi tu passasti, eterno
 sospiro mio: passasti: e fia compagna 170
 d'ogni mio vago immaginar, di tutti
 i miei teneri sensi, i tristi e cari
 moti del cor, la rimembranza acerba.

Canto notturno di un pastore errante dell'Asia

Che fai tu, luna, in ciel? dimmi, che fai,
 silenziosa luna?
 Sorgi la sera, e vai,
 contemplando i deserti; indi ti posi.
 Ancor non sei tu paga 5
 di riandare i sempiterni calli?

your voice's sound, as one day,
when every distant accent
of your lips, that might reach me, would pale
my face? Other times. Your days
were, my sweet love. You passed. To others
the passing through the earth today is allotted,
and the inhabiting of these odorous hills.
But rapidly you passed, and like a dream
was your life. Dancing you went; joy shone
before you, that confident imagining,
that light of youth shone in your eyes,
when fate quenched them, and you lay still.
Ah Nerina! In my heart reigns
the ancient love. If still to feasts sometimes,
if to parties I go, within me
I say: o Nerina, for feasts
you dress yourself no more, no more you go.
If May returns, and bouquets and music
lovers go bringing to the girls,
I say: my Nerina, for you
spring never returns, nor returns love.
Each serene day, each flowery
slope I see, each pleasure that I feel,
I say: Nerina now no more rejoices; the fields,
the air she does not see. Ah you passed, my
eternal sigh: you passed, and the companion will be
of every fair imagining of mine, of all
my tender senses, of the sad and dear
stirrings of the heart, the bitter recollection.

Nocturnal song of a wandering shepherd of Asia

What are you doing, moon, in the sky?
tell me, what are you doing, silent moon?
You rise in the evening, and you go,
contemplating the deserts; then you set.
Are you not weary yet
of going over the everlasting paths?

Ancor non prendi a schivo, ancor sei vaga di mirar queste valli? Somiglia alla tua vita la vita del pastore.	10
Sorge in sul primo albore; move la greggia oltre pel campo, e vede greggi, fontane ed erbe; poi stanco si riposa in su la sera: altro mai non ispera.	15
Dimmi, o luna: a che vale al pastor la sua vita, la vostra vita a voi? dimmi: ove tende questo vagar mio breve, il tuo corso immortale?	20
Vecchierel bianco, infermo, mezzo vestito e scalzo, con gravissimo fascio in su le spalle, per montagna e per valle, per sassi acuti, ed alta rena, e fratte,	25
al vento, alla tempesta, e quando avvampa l'ora, e quando poi gela, corre via, corre, anela, varca torrenti e stagni, cade, risorge, e più e più s'affretta,	30
senza posa o ristoro, lacerato, sanguinoso; infin ch'arriva colà dove la via e dove il tanto affaticar fu volto: abisso orrido, immenso,	35
ov'ei precipitando, il tutto obblia. Vergine luna, tale è la vita mortale.	
Nasce l'uomo a fatica, ed è rischio di morte il nascimento.	40
Prova pena e tormento per prima cosa; e in sul principio stesso la madre e il genitore il prende a consolar dell'esser nato.	
Poi che crescendo viene, l'uno e l'altro il sostiene, e via pur sempre con atti e con parole	45

Don't you yet want to shun, are you still fond
of looking on these valleys?
Like your life
is the shepherd's life.
He rises at first dawn,
moves the flocks over the fields, and sees
flocks, springs and grass;
then tired he rests at evening:
he hopes for nothing else.
Tell me, o moon: of what use
to the shepherd his life,
your life to you? tell me, where does it lead,
this brief wandering of mine,
where your immortal course?

Little old man, white-haired, unsteady,
half-dressed and barefoot,
with the heaviest bundle on his shoulders,
over mountain and valley,
sharp rocks and sand and brush,
in the wind, in the storm, and in the blazing
noon, and then when it freezes,
runs on, runs, pants,
crosses torrents and swamps,
falls, rises again, and hurries more and more,
without pause or rest,
in rags, bloody, until he arrives
there where the way
and so much labor was directed:
a horrid, immense chasm,
where he, plunging, everything forgets.
Virgin moon, such
is mortal life.

Laborious is man's birth,
and fraught with risk of death.
Pain and torment are the first things
he experiences, and from the very start
mother and father
take to consoling him for being born.
Then, as he grows,
they both sustain him, and ever
with actions and with words

studiasi fargli core, e consolarlo dell'umano stato: altro ufficio più grato non si fa da parenti alla lor prole. Ma perchè dare al sole, perchè reggere in vita chi poi di quella consolar convenga? Se la vita è sventura perchè da noi si dura? Intatta luna, tale è lo stato mortale. Ma tu mortal non sei, e forse del mio dir poco ti cale.	50
Pur tu, solinga, eterna peregrina, che sì pensosa sei, tu forse intendi, questo viver terreno, il patir nostro, il sospirar, che sia; che sia questo morir, questo supremo scolar del sembiante, e perir dalla terra, e venir meno ad ogni usata, amante compagnia. E tu certo comprendi il perchè delle cose, e vedi il frutto del mattin, della sera, del tacito, infinito andar del tempo. Tu sai, tu certo, a qual suo dolce amore rida la primavera, a chi giovi l'ardore, e che procacci il verno co'suoi ghiacci. Mille cose sai tu, mille discopri, che son celate al semplice pastore. Spesso quand'io ti miro star così muta in sul deserto piano, che, in suo giro lontano, al ciel confina; ovver con la mia greggia seguirmi viaggiando a mano a mano; e quando miro in cielo arder le stelle; dico fra me pensando: a che tante facelle? che fa l'aria infinita, e quel profondo infinito seren? che vuol dir questa solitudine immensa? ed io che sono?	55 60 65 70 75 80 85

they strive to give him heart,
and to console him for the human state:
no more welcome deed
is done by parents for their children.
But why give to the sun,
why keep alive
one who then of life will have to be consoled?
If life is misfortune
why do we endure it?
Intact moon, such
is the mortal state.
But mortal you are not,
and perhaps what I say little you care.

Yet you, lonely, eternal pilgrim,
you who are so pensive, you perhaps understand
what is this earthly living,
our suffering, our sighing;
what is this dying, this final
blanching of one's face,
and perishing from earth, and forsaking
every loving company we are used to.
And you surely understand
the why of things, and see the fruit
of morning, of evening,
of the infinite, tacit going of time.
You know, for sure, at what sweet love of hers
spring smiles,
who benefits from the scorching heat, and what proffers
the winter with its ice.
A thousand things you know, a thousand you discover
that to the simple shepherd are concealed.
Often when I watch you
staying so mute over the desert plain
which in its distant sweep meets with the sky,
or yet following me step by step
as I journey with my flock,
and when I watch the stars blaze in the sky,
I say to myself thinking:
why so many lights?
what is this infinite air doing, and that deep
infinite serene? what does this
immense solitude mean? and what am I?

So with myself I speak: and of the vault
measureless and superb,
and of the innumerable family;
of so much work, and motion
of each celestial and each earthly thing,
pauselessly turning,
ever to return to where they started from,
any purpose, any fruit
I cannot guess. But you for sure,
immortal maid, know it all.
This I know and feel,
that from the eternal rounds,
from my frail being,
some good or contentment
others may draw; to me life is evil.

O resting flock of mine, oh blissful one,
whose misery, I don't believe, you know!
I bear you so much envy!
Not only because you go
so nearly free of distress,
that every dearth, every hurt,
every extreme fear you immediately forget;
but more because to you tedium is unknown.
When you lie in the shade, on the grass,
you are quiet and content,
and a large part of the year
you spend in that state without being bored.
And I too sit on the grass, in the shade,
and an annoyance besets
my mind and a spur almost pricks me
so that, sitting, I am farther than ever
from finding peace or rest.
And yet I long for nothing,
and so far I have no cause for tears.
What you enjoy or how much,
I cannot tell; but fortunate you are.
And there is little that I still enjoy,
o my flock, and not only of that I complain.
If you could speak, I'd ask:
tell me: why lying
idly, at his fair ease,
each animal is content;

me, s'io giaccio in riposo, il tedio assale?

Forse s'avess'io l'ale
da volar su le nubi,
e noverar le stelle ad una ad una, 135
o come il tuono errar di giogo in giogo,
più felice sarei, dolce mia greggia,
più felice sarei, candida luna.
O forse erra dal vero,
mirando all'altrui sorte, il mio pensiero: 140
forse in qual forma, in quale
stato che sia, dentro covile o cuna,
è funesto a chi nasce il dì natale.

La quiete dopo la tempesta

Passata è la tempesta:
odo augelli far festa, e la gallina,
tornata in su la via,
che ripete il suo verso. Ecco il sereno 5
rompe là da ponente, alla montagna;
sgombrasi la campagna,
e chiaro nella valle il fiume appare.
Ogni cor si rallegra, in ogni lato
risorge il romorio,
torna il lavoro usato. 10
L'artigiano a mirar l'umido cielo,
con l'opra in man, cantando,
fassi in su l'uscio; a prova
vien fuor la femminetta a còr dell'acqua
della novella piova; 15
e l'erbauol rinnova
di sentiero in sentiero
il grido giornaliero.
Ecco il Sol che ritorna, ecco sorride
per li poggi e le ville. Apre i balconi, 20
apre terrazzi e logge la famiglia:
e, dalla via corrente, odi lontano
tintinnio di sonagli; il carro stride
del passegger che il suo cammin ripiglia.

me, if I lie at rest, tedium assails.

Perhaps had I the wings
to fly over the clouds
and one by one single out the stars,
or like thunder roam from range to range,
happier I would be, sweet flock of mine,
happier I would be, unblemished moon.
Or perhaps my thought,
looking at the lot of others, strays from truth:
perhaps in whatever form, in whatever
state it be, in den or cradle,
woeful to who is born is his day of birth.

The calm after the storm

The storm is over:
I hear birds rejoicing, and the hen,
back on the road,
as she repeats her call. Look, the serene sky
breaks forth west over the mountain;
the country is disencumbered,
and the river appears clear in the valley.
Each heart is cheered, on every side
the stir resumes,
the usual work returns.
The artisan, work in hand and singing,
shows up at his door,
to look at the fresh sky; a girl
promptly comes out for a draft
of new rain-water;
and the herb-seller
from lane to lane
renews his daily cry.
Here's the Sun that returns, here it smiles
on slopes and farms. People
open windows, open terraces and loggias:
and from the highway, you hear a distant
jingling of bells; the traveller's coach creaks,
again taking to the road.

Si rallegra ogni core.	25
Si dolce, sì gradita	
quand'è, com'or, la vita?	
quando con tanto amore	
l'uomo a' suoi studi intende?	
o torna all'opre? o cosa nova imprende?	30
quando de' mali suoi men si ricorda?	
Piacer figlio d'affanno;	
gioia vana, ch'è frutto	
del passato timore, onde si scosse	
e paventò la morte	35
chi la vita abborria;	
onde in lungo tormento,	
fredde, tacite, smorte,	
sudàr le genti e palpitàr, vedendo	
mossi alle nostre offese	40
folgori, nemi e vento.	
O natura cortese,	
son questi i doni tuoi,	
questi i dilette sono	
che tu porgi ai mortali. Uscir di pena	45
è diletto fra noi.	
Pene tu spargi a larga mano; il duolo	
spontaneo sorge: e di piacer, quel tanto	
che per mostro e miracolo talvolta	
nasce d'affanno, è gran guadagno. Umana	50
prole cara agli eterni! assai felice	
se respirar ti lice	
d'alcun dolor: beata	
se te d'ogni dolor morte risana.	

Il sabato del villaggio

La donzelletta vien dalla campagna,	
in sul calar del sole,	
col suo fascio dell'erba; e reca in mano	
un mazzolin di rose e di viole,	
onde, siccome suole,	5
ornare ella si appresta	

Cheered is each heart.
So sweet, so welcome
when is life, as now?
when else, with so much love,
does man pursue his studies?
or to his work return? or take on something new?
when does he remember less his woes?
Pleasure, child of anguish;
vain joy, fruit
of past fear, from which even he
who loathed life, trembled
and dreaded death;
from which in long torment,
men, cold, silent, wan,
sweated and panted, seeing
lightning, clouds and wind
moving to harm us.

O courteous nature,
these are your gifts,
these the delights
which you bestow upon mortals. Deliverance from pain
is for us a delight.
You strew pain with lavish hand; sorrow
spontaneous rises: and what pleasure
by miracle and magic is sometimes born
of grief, is a great gain. Human
offspring dear to the eternal! happy indeed
if you are allowed to pause for breath
from any pain: blissful
if death heals you of every pain.

The village Saturday

The girl comes from the fields,
toward sunset,
with her bundle of grass; and in her hand she brings
a bouquet of roses and of violets,
with which, as is her way,
tomorrow on the holiday,

she intends to adorn her breast and hair.
The little old woman
sits spinning with her neighbors on the stairs,
facing the setting sun;
and goes on telling stories of her own good times,
when on the holidays she would adorn herself,
and, still healthy and nimble,
dance in the evening with those
whom in the fairest age she had as friends.
Already the air darkens all around,
deepens the blue, and the shadows return
down from the hills and roofs,
at the whitening of the risen moon.
Now the bells announce
the coming holiday;
and you would say
the heart finds comfort in that sound.
Children in a throng, shouting
in the tiny square,
make a merry noise
jumping here and there:
and meanwhile the laborer, whistling,
returns to his frugal meal,
and within he thinks of the day of rest.

Then when all other lights around are quenched,
and everything else is still,
you hear the hammer strike, you hear the saw
of the carpenter, who stays awake
in his closed shop, with a lantern,
and hurries and strives
to finish his work before dawn lightens.

This of the seven is the most welcome day,
full of hope and of joy:
tomorrow the hours will bring
sadness and boredom, and to his usual toil
will each one in thought return.

Playful boy,
that budding age of yours
is like a cheerful day,
a day clear, serene,

che precorre alla festa di tua vita.
Godi, fanciullo mio; stato soave,
stagion lieta è cotesta.
Altro dirti non vo'; ma la tua festa
ch'anco tardi a venir non ti sia grave.

50

Il pensiero dominante

Dolcissimo, possente
dominator di mia profonda mente;
terribile, ma caro
dono del ciel; consorte
ai lùgubri miei giorni,
pensier che innanzi a me sì spesso torni.

5

Di tua natura arcana
chi non favella? il suo poter fra noi
chi non sentì? Pur sempre
che in dir gli effetti suoi
le umane lingue il sentir proprio sprona,
par novo ad ascoltar ciò ch'ei ragiona.

10

Come solinga è fatta
la mente mia d'allora
che tu quivi prendesti a far dimora!
Ratto d'intorno intorno al par del lampo
gli altri pensieri miei
tutti si dileguar. Siccome torre
in solitario campo,
tu stai solo, gigante, in mezzo a lei.

15

20

Che divenute son, fuor di te solo,
tutte l'opre terrene,
tutta intera la vita al guardo mio!
Che intollerabil noia
gli ozi, i commerci usati,
e di vano piacer la vana spene,
allato a quella gioia,
gioia celeste che da te mi viene!

25

preceding your life's feast.
Enjoy it, my child; blissful state,
happy season is that.
I'll say no more; but don't let
any delay of your feast be a burden to you.

The dominant thought

Sweetest, mighty
swayer of my inmost mind;
terrible, but dear
gift of the sky: consort
of my somber days,
thought, so often before me returning.

Of your uncanny nature
who does not speak? its power among us
who has not felt? Yet whenever
one's own feeling spurs men's tongues
to tell of its effects,
new to our hearing seems that which it says.

How lonely
my mind is made
since you took upon yourself to inhabit there!
Rapidly all around like lightning
my other thoughts
all disappeared. Even as a tower
in a solitary field,
you stand alone, gigantic in its midst.

Apart from you alone, to my sight,
what have all worldly deeds,
what has all life become!
What an intolerable bore are
leisures, everyday exchanges,
and of vain pleasure the vain hope,
beside that joy,
celestial joy that comes to me from you!

Come da' nudi sassi
dello scabro Apennino 30
a un campo verde che lontan sorrida
volge gli occhi bramoso il pellegrino;
tal io dal secco ed aspro
mondano conversar vogliosamente,
quasi in lieto giardino, a te ritorno, 35
e ristora i miei sensi il tuo soggiorno.

Quasi incredibil parmi
che la vita infelice e il mondo sciocco
già per gran tempo assai
senza te sopportai; 40
quasi intender non posso
come d'altri desiri,
fuor ch'a te somiglianti, altri sospiri.

Giammai d'allor che in pria
questa vita che sia per prova intesi, 45
timor di morte non mi strinse il petto.
Oggi mi pare un gioco
quella che il mondo inetto,
talor lodando, ognora abborre e trema,
necessitate estrema; 50
e se periglio appar, con un sorriso
le sue minacce a contemplar m'affiso.

Sempre i codardi, e l'alme
ingenerose, abbiette
ebbi in dispregio. Or punge ogni atto indegno 55
subito i sensi miei;
move l'alma ogni esempio
dell'umana viltà subito a sdegno.
Di questa età superba,
che di vote speranze si nutrica, 60
vaga di ciance, e di virtù nemica;
stolta, che l'util chiede,
e inutile la vita
quindi più sempre divenir non vede;
maggior mi sento. A scherno 65
ho gli umani giudizi; e il vario volgo
a' bei pensieri infesto,
e degno tuo disprezzator, calpesto.

Even as when from the bare rocks
of the rugged Apennine
to a green field that smiles to him from far away
the traveller with longing turns his eyes,
so I from the dry and brash
mundane conversation yearningly,
as to a delightful garden, return to you,
and your sojourn my senses restores.

It seems almost incredible to me
that this unhappy life and the foolish world
for so very long a time
without you I could have borne;
scarcely can I understand
how with other desires than those
that resemble yours, others may sigh.

Never, since I first learned
through experience what this life might be,
has fear of death clenched my breast.
Today what the inept world,
while praising it at times, ever abhors and trembles at,
our last necessity,
seems a game to me;
and should danger loom, I with a smile am set
to contemplate its threat.

Always have I despised
cowards, and ungenerous,
abject souls. Instantly any unworthy act
now stings my senses;
any example of man's vileness
at once moves my soul to indignation.
To this haughty age,
nourished on hollow hopes,
fond of gossip, and enemy of virtue,
foolish, asking the useful,
and not seeing life
getting ever more useless,
I feel superior. Human judgments
I scorn; and the motley crowd,
hostile to fine thoughts
and fit disparager of you, I tread upon.

A quello onde tu movi, quale affetto non cede? anzi qual altro affetto se non quell'uno intra i mortali ha sede? Avarizia, superbia, odio, disdegno, studio d'onor, di regno, che sono altro che voglie al paragon di lui? Solo un affetto vive tra noi: quest'uno, prepotente signore, dieder l'eterne leggi all'uman core.	70 75
Pregio non ha, non ha ragion la vita se non per lui, per lui ch'all'uomo è tutto; sola discolpa al fato, che noi mortali in terra pose a tanto patir senz'altro frutto; solo per cui talvolta, non alla gente stolta, al cor non vile la vita della morte è più gentile.	80 85
Per còr le gioie tue, dolce pensiero, provar gli umani affanni, e sostener molt'anni questa vita mortal, fu non indegno; ed ancor tornerei, così qual son de' nostri mali esperto, verso un tal segno a incominciare il corso: che tra le sabbie e tra il vipereo morso, giammai finor sì stanco per lo mortal deserto non venni a te, che queste nostre pene vincer non mi paresse un tanto bene.	90 95
Che mondo mai, che nova immensità, che paradiso è quello là dove spesso il tuo stupendo incanto parmi innalzar! dov'io, sott'altra luce che l'usata errando, il mio terreno stato e tutto quanto il ver pongo in obbligo! Tali son, credo, i sogni degli'immortali. Ahi finalmente un sogno	100 105

To that from which you stem,
what passion will not yield?
Indeed what other passion
if not that one alone dwells among mortals?
Avarice, haughtiness, hate, disdain,
desire of honor, of ruling,
what are they other than whims
compared to this? One passion alone
among us lives: this one,
overbearing lord,
the eternal laws gave to the human heart.

Life has no worth, no reason
if not for this, for this which to man is all;
sole excuse of fate,
that exposed us mortals on earth
to so much suffering without other returns;
the only one for which at times,
not to foolish people, not to the base of heart,
life is more gentle than death.

To reap your joys, sweet thought,
tasting human woes,
and sustaining for many years
this mortal life, was not unworthy;
and again, with such a goal in view,
even as I am, an expert in our ills,
its course I would renew.
For through the mortal desert,
'twixt sands and viper's bite,
I never came to you so weary
as to think that such a joy
would not defeat our sorrows.

Whatever world, what new
immensity, what paradise is that
to which your stupendous enchantment
often seems to lift me! where I,
wandering beneath other than the usual light,
my earthly state
and all of truth commit to oblivion!
Such, I believe, are the dreams
of the immortals. Ah in the end a dream

in molta parte onde s'abbella il vero
sei tu, dolce pensiero; 110
sogno e palese error. Ma di natura,
infra i leggiadri errori,
divina sei; perché sì viva e forte,
che incontro al ver tenacemente dura,
e spesso al ver s'adequa, 115
nè si dilegua pria, che in grembo a morte.

E tu per certo, o mio pensier, tu solo
vitale ai giorni miei,
cagion diletta d'infiniti affanni,
meco sarai per morte a un tempo spento: 120
ch'a vivi segni dentro l'alma io sento
che in perpetuo signor dato mi sei.
Altri gentili inganni
soleami il vero aspetto
più sempre infievolir. Quanto più torno 125
a riveder colei
della qual teco ragionando io vivo,
cresce quel gran diletto,
cresce quel gran delirio, ond'io respiro.
Angelica beltade! 130
Parmi ogni più bel volto, ovunque io miro,
quasi una finta imago
il tuo volto imitar. Tu sola fonte
d'ogni altra leggiadria,
sola vera beltà parmi che sia. 135

Da che ti vidi pria,
di qual mia seria cura ultimo obbietto
non fosti tu? quanto del giorno è scorso,
ch'io di te non pensassi? ai sogni miei
la tua sovrana imago 140
quante volte mancò? Bella qual sogno,
angelica sembianza,
nella terrena stanza,
nell'alte vie dell'universo intero,
che chiedo io mai, che spero 145
altro che gli occhi tuoi veder più vago?
altro più dolce aver che il tuo pensiero?

where truth is in large part embellished
are you, sweet thought;
a dream and clearly an illusion.
But, among blithe illusions,
of a divine nature you are, because so live and strong;
one which, confronted with the truth, tenaciously endures,
and often matches truth,
nor fades, till in the lap of death.

And you for sure, o my thought, you alone
vital to my days,
beloved cause of infinite distresses,
with me through death will be at once extinguished:
for by vivid signs within my soul I feel
that you were given to me as my perpetual lord.
Other gentle illusions
would by the true aspect
be made ever more faint. The more I turn
to look again on her
through whom speaking with you I live,
the more grows that great delight,
grows that great delirium, whence I breathe.
Angelic beauty!
Every fairest face, wherever I look,
to me seems, like almost a feigned image,
to imitate your visage. You the only source
of every other loveliness,
the only true beauty to me seem to be.

Since first I saw you,
of what serious care of mine
weren't you the final object? how much of the day went by
that I didn't think of you? how many times
did your sovereign image
not appear in my dreams? Fair as a dream,
angelic semblance,
in the terrestrial chamber,
in the lofty paths of the whole universe,
what do I ask, what do I hope
ever to see lovelier than your eyes?
ever to have sweeter than your thought?

Amore e Morte

Muor giovane colui ch'al cielo è caro.

MENANDRO.

Fratelli, a un tempo stesso, Amore e Morte
ingenerò la sorte.

Cose quaggiù sì belle
altre il mondo non ha, non han le stelle.

Nasce dall'uno il bene, 5

nasce il piacer maggiore
che per lo mar dell'essere si trova;

l'altra ogni gran dolore, 10

ogni gran male annulla.

Bellissima fanciulla, 10

dolce a veder, non quale

la si dipinge la codarda gente,

gode il fanciullo Amore 15

accompagnar sovente;

e sorvolano insiem la via mortale, 15

primi conforti d'ogni saggio core.

Né cor fu mai più saggio

che percosso d'amor, né mai più forte

sprezzò l'infausta vita, 20

né per altro signore

come per questo a perigliar fu pronto:

ch'ove tu porgi aita,

Amor, nasce il coraggio,

o si ridesta; e sapiente in opre, 25

non in pensiero invan, siccome suole,

divien l'umana prole. 25

Quando novellamente

nasce nel cor profondo

un amoroso affetto,

languido e stanco insiem con esso in petto 30

un desiderio di morir si sente:

come, non so: ma tale

d'amor vero e possente è il primo effetto.

Forse gli occhi spaura

allor questo deserto: a sé la terra 35

forse il mortale inabitabil fatta

Love and Death

He dies young who is dear to the sky.

MENANDER

Brothers were Love and Death,
at once by fate conceived.
Other things down here so beautiful
the world has not, nor have the stars.
Of one is goodness born,
born the highest delight
that in the sea of being is to be found;
the other any pain,
any great evil ends.
Fairest maiden,
sweet to see, not such
as vulgar people picture,
often the boy Love
enjoys accompanying;
and over the mortal way they fly together,
first comforts of every wise heart.
Nor heart was ever wiser
than when struck by love. Nor ever did it more strongly
scorn ill-fated life,
nor was it so ready to face peril
for any other master as for this one:
so that where you bring aid,
Love, courage is born,
or it reawakes; and skilled in deeds,
not merely in thought, to no avail,
as is usual, becomes the human breed.

When newly
a loving passion
deep in the heart is born,
languid and weary with it in the breast
you feel a wish to die:
how, I know not: but such is the first effect
of powerful and true love.
Perhaps this desert then
frightens the eyes: perhaps man sees
the earth now made
uninhabitable for him

vede omai senza quella
 nova, sola, infinita
 felicità che il suo pensier figura:
 ma per cagion di lei grave procella 40
 presentando in suo cor, brama quiete,
 brama raccorsi in porto
 dinanzi al fier disio,
 che già, ruggiando, intorno intorno oscura.

Poi, quando tutto avvolge 45
 la formidabil possa,
 e fulmina nel cor l'invitta cura,
 quante volte implorata
 con desiderio intenso,
 Morte, sei tu dall'affannoso amante! 50
 quante la sera, e quante,
 abbandonando all'alba il corpo stanco,
 sé beato chiamò s'indi giammai
 non rilevasse il fianco,
 né tornasse a veder l'amara luce! 55
 E spesso al suon della funebre squilla,
 al canto che conduce
 la gente morta al sempiterno obbligo,
 con più sospiri ardenti
 dall'imo petto invidiò colui 60
 che tra gli spenti ad abitar sen giva.
 Fin la negletta plebe,
 l'uom della villa, ignaro
 d'ogni virtù che da saper deriva,
 fin la donzella timidetta e schiva, 65
 che già di morte al nome
 sentì rizzar le chiome,
 osa alla tomba, alle funeree bende
 fermar lo sguardo di costanza pieno,
 osa ferro e veleno 70
 meditar lungamente,
 e nell'indotta mente
 la gentilezza del morir comprende.
 Tanto alla morte inclina
 d'amor la disciplina. Anco sovente, 75
 a tal venuto il gran travaglio interno
 che sostener nol può forza mortale,
 o cede il corpo frale

without that new, sole, infinite
felicity which in his mind he pictures:
but because of it foreseeing in his heart
a grievous storm, he longs for quiet,
longs for a haven,
before the fierce desire, which, roaring,
already darkens all around him.

Then, when the formidable power
everything enfolds,
and flashes in the heart the unvanquished care,
how many times implored
with intense longing,
Death, are you by the distraught lover!
how many times at evening, and how many,
yielding his tired body to the dawn,
blessed he called himself if he should never
lift his frame,
or rise to see the bitter light again!
And often at the sound of the funereal toll,
at the chant that leads
the dead to oblivion everlasting,
with many an ardent sigh
from deep within the breast he envied him
who went to inhabit the world of the departed.
Even poor folk, neglected,
the peasant unversed in any virtue
that from knowledge is derived,
even the timid, bashful girl,
who at death's mere name
felt her hair stand on end,
dares fix upon the tomb, upon the pall
her steadfast gaze,
dares steel and poison
meditate a long time,
and in her unlearned mind
the gentleness of dying she comprehends.
So much toward death
love's discipline inclines. Often too,
when the great internal travail reaches the point
in which mortal strength no longer can sustain it,
either the frail body yields

to the terrible stresses, and in this form
Death prevails through its brotherly power;
or Love spurs so deep within,
that on their own the uncultured country boy,
the tender girl
with violent hand
lay their young bodies on the ground.
Laughs at their doings the world,
to whom peace and old age may heaven allow.

To the fervent, the happy,
the brave souls
may fate assign one or the other of you,
sweet lords, friends
to the human family,
whose might in the immense universe
no power resembles or exceeds,
other than the power of fate.
And you, who ever since my earliest years
I have always honored and invoked,
beautiful Death, piteous
you alone on earth of human woes,
if ever you were
hallowed by me, if I tried to compensate
for the insults of the ungrateful
to your divine state,
tarry no more, bow
to my unusual prayers,
close to the light at last
these sad eyes, o queen of time.
Me surely you will find, when
at my prayer you will unfold your wings,
with unbowed brow, armed,
and renitent to fate,
the hand that flailing colors itself
in my innocent blood
not replenishing with praise,
not blessing, as through ancient baseness
is man's custom;
every vain hope with which the world
consoles itself like children,
every foolish comfort
casting away from me; naught else ever

sperar, se non te sola;
solo aspettar sereno
quel dì ch'io pieghi addormentato il volto
nel tuo virgineo seno.

A se stesso

Or poserai per sempre,
stanco mio cor. Però l'inganno estremo,
ch'eterno io mi credei. Però. Ben sento,
in noi di cari inganni,
non che la speme, il desiderio è spento. 5
Posa per sempre. Assai
palpitasti. Non val cosa nessuna
i moti tuoi, né di sospiri è degna
la terra. Amaro e noia
la vita, altro mai nulla; e fango è il mondo. 10
T'acqueta omai. Dispera
l'ultima volta. Al gener nostro il fato
non donò che il morire. Omai disprezza
te, la natura, il brutto
poter che, ascoso, a comun danno impera, 15
e l'infinita vanità del tutto.

Sopra il ritratto di una bella donna sculpito nel monumento sepolcrale della medesima

Tal fosti: or qui sotterra
polve e scheletro sei. Su l'ossa e il fango
immobilmente collocato invano,
muto, mirando dell'etadi il volo,
sta, di memoria solo 5
e di dolor custode, il simulacro
della scorsa beltà. Quel dolce sguardo,
che tremar fe', se, come or sembra, immoto

hoping for, other than you alone;
only serenely awaiting
that day when I may lay my face
on your virginal breast.

To himself

Now you will rest forever,
my tired heart. The last illusion perished
which I believed eternal. It perished. Well I know,
in us of dear illusions,
not just the hope, the desire is quenched.
Rest forever. Enough
you throbbed. Nothing deserves
your stirrings, nor is the earth worth
a sigh. Bitterness and boredom
life, nothing else ever; and mud is the world.
Quiet now. Despair
for the last time. Fate to our kind
gave only dying as a gift.
Now scorn nature, the ugly
power which, hidden, rules for the common evil,
and the infinite vanity of it all.

On the portrait of a beautiful woman sculptured on her sepulchral monument

Such were you: now here underground
dust and skeleton you are. On bones and mud
placed motionless in vain,
mute, gazing on the flight of ages,
stands, custodian only
of memory and of sorrow, the simulacrum
of your past beauty. That sweet look
which made one tremble, if, as it now seems to,

in altrui s'affisò; quel labbro, ond'alto
 par, come d'urna piena, 10
 traboccare il piacer; quel collo, cinto
 già di desio; quell'amorosa mano,
 che spesso, ove fu porta,
 sentì gelida far la man che strinse;
 e il seno, onde la gente 15
 visibilmente di pallor si tinse,
 furo alcun tempo: or fango
 ed ossa sei: la vista
 vituperosa e trista un sasso asconde.

Così riduce il fato 20
 qual sembianza fra noi parve più viva
 immagine del ciel. Misterio eterno
 dell'esser nostro. Oggi d'eccelsi, immensi
 pensieri e sensi inenarrabil fonte,
 beltà grandeggia, e pare, 25
 quale splendor vibrato
 da natura immortal su queste arene,
 di sovrumani fati,
 di fortunati regni e d'aurei mondi
 segno e sicura spene 30
 dare al mortale stato:
 diman, per lieve forza,
 sozzo a vedere, abominoso, abbietto
 divien quel che fu dianzi
 quasi angelico aspetto, 35
 e dalle menti insieme
 quel che da lui moveva
 ammirabil concetto, si dilegua.

Desiderii infiniti
 e visioni altere 40
 crea nel vago pensiero,
 per natural virtù, dotto contento;
 onde per mar delizioso, arcano
 erra lo spirto umano,
 quasi come a diporto 45
 ardito notator per l'Oceano:
 ma se un discorde accento
 fere l'orecchio, in nulla
 torna quel paradiso in un momento.

it steadfastly fixed itself on another; that lip,
whence deep, as from a full urn,
pleasure seems to overflow; that neck, girt
once with desire; that lovely hand,
that often, when given,
felt turn cold the hand it shook;
and the breast, whence people
tinged themselves visibly with pallor,
were at some time: now mud
and bone you are: the loathsome
and vile sight a stone conceals.

Thus fate reduces
whatever semblance among us seemed the most live
image of heaven. Eternal mystery
of our being. Today of lofty, immense
thoughts and feelings ineffable source,
beauty holds sway, and seems,
like splendor flashed
by immortal nature on these shores,
to give the mortal state
sign and sure hope
of superhuman destinies,
of fortunate reigns and golden worlds:
tomorrow, by a slight force,
grimy to look at, abominable, abject
becomes what a while ago
was almost angelic aspect,
and from the mind also
vanishes the admirable
vision it inspired.

Fine harmony, by its own natural virtue,
creates in the keen mind
infinite desires
and winged visions,
whence through delightful and uncharted seas
wanders the human soul,
almost like a bold swimmer
in the ocean for his sport:
but if a discordant accent
wounds the ear, that paradise
in an instant turns to naught.

Natura umana, or come,	50
se frale in tutto e vile,	
se polve ed ombra sei, tant'alto senti?	
Se in parte anco gentile,	
come i più degni tuoi moti e pensieri	
son così di leggeri	55
da sì basse cagioni e desti e spenti?	

Il tramonto della luna

Quale in notte solinga,	
sovra campagne inargentate ed acque,	
là 've zefiro aleggia,	
e mille vaghi aspetti	
e ingannevoli obbietti	5
fincon l'ombre lontane	
infra l'onde tranquille	
e rami e siepi e collinette e ville;	
giunta al confin del cielo,	
dietro Apennino od Alpe, o del Tirreno	10
nell'infinito seno	
scende la luna; e si scolora il mondo;	
spariscon l'ombre, ed una	
oscurità la valle e il monte imbruna;	
orba la notte resta,	15
e cantando, con mesta melodia,	
l'estremo albor della fuggente luce,	
che dianzi gli fu duce,	
saluta il carrettier dalla sua via;	
tal si dilegua, e tale	20
lascia l'età mortale	
la giovinezza. In fuga	
van l'ombre e le sembianze	
dei dilettoni inganni; e vengon meno	
le lontane speranze,	25
ove s'appoggia la mortal natura.	
Abbandonata, oscura	
resta la vita. In lei porgendo il guardo,	

Human nature, how now,
if frail in everything and vile,
if dust and shade you are, you feel so deeply?
If in part gentle too,
how are the worthiest of your thoughts and emotions
so lightly
by such base causes roused and quenched?

The setting of the moon

As in the solitude of night,
over silvery fields and waters,
there where zephyr flutters,
and the distant shadows feign
a thousand vague aspects
and deceiving objects
among the tranquil waves
and branches and hedges and little hills and farms,
having reached the border of the sky,
behind Apennine or Alp, or
in the infinite bosom of the Tyrrhenian,
sets the moon, and the world is discolored;
the shadows disappear, and one
obscurity darkens mountain and valley;
night is left bereaved,
and the carter from the road,
singing, with melancholy tune,
to the last glimmer of the fleeting light,
which a while ago led him, bids adieu;

even so youth disappears
and leaves the mortal years.
Fleeing go
the semblances and shadows
of delightful illusions; and fade
the distant hopes,
on which mortal nature depends.
Abandoned, dark
is left life. Setting his eyes upon it,

cerca il confuso viatore invano
del cammin lungo che avanzar si sente
meta o ragione; e vede
che a sé l'umana sede,
esso a lei veramente è fatto estrano. 30

Troppo felice e lieta
nostra misera sorte
parve lassù, se il giovanile stato,
dove ogni ben di mille pene è frutto,
durasse tutto della vita il corso. 35

Troppo mite decreto
quel che sentenza ogni animale a morte,
s'anco mezza la via
lor non si desse in pria
della terribil morte assai più dura. 40

D'intelletti immortali
degno trovato, estremo
di tutti i mali, ritrovàr gli eterni
la vecchiezza, ove fosse
incolume il desio, la speme estinta,
secche le fonti del piacer, le pene
maggiori sempre, e non più dato il bene. 45 50

Voi, collinette e piagge,
caduto lo splendor che all'occidente
inargentava della notte il velo,
orfane ancor gran tempo
non resterete: che dall'altra parte
tosto vedrete il cielo 55

imbiancar novamente, e sorger l'alba:
alla qual poscia seguitando il sole,
e folgorando intorno
con sue fiamme possenti,
di lucidi torrenti 60

inonderà con voi gli eterei campi.
Ma la vita mortal, poi che la bella
giovinezza sparì, non si colora
d'altra luce giammai, né d'altra aurora. 65
Vedova è insino al fine; ed alla notte
che l'altre etadi oscura,
segno poser gli Dei la sepoltura.

the confused traveller,
seeks in vain goal or reason
for the long way he feels he has to go;
and he sees that to him man's abode,
and he to it have really become strangers.

Too happy and glad
our wretched lot
seemed to those above, if youth's state,
where each bliss is the fruit of a thousand pains,
should last our whole life long.
Too mild a decree
that which sentences each creature to death,
if also half the journey
were not first meted out to them
very much harder than terrible death.
A find worthy
of immortal minds,
the eternal ones discovered old age,
the utmost of all evils, wherein
desire undiminished, hope should extinguished be,
dry pleasure's font, pains
ever greater, and bliss no more bestowed.

You, little hills and slopes,
fallen the splendor that to the west
silvered the veil of night,
orphans won't remain
much longer, for from the other side
soon you shall see the sky
whiten anew, and dawn arise;
then the sun following upon it,
and flashing all around
its puissant flames,
with lucid streams
will flood you and the ethereal fields.
But mortal life, once beautiful
youth has disappeared, never colors itself
of other light, or other dawn.
Widow it is to the end; and for the night
that darkens the other ages,
the Gods set burial as a goal.

La ginestra o il fiore del deserto

E gli uomini vollero piuttosto le tenebre che la luce.
GIOVANNI, III, 19.

Qui su l'arida schiena
del formidabil monte
sterminator Vesevo,
la qual null'altro allegra arbor né fiore,
tuoi cespi solitari intorno spargi, 5
odorata ginestra,
contenta dei deserti. Anco ti vidi
de' tuoi steli abbellir l'erme contrade
che cingon la cittade
la qual fu donna de' mortali un tempo, 10
e del perduto impero
par che col grave e taciturno aspetto
faccian fede e ricordo al passeggero.
Or ti riveggo in questo suol, di tristi
lochi e dal mondo abbandonati amante, 15
e d'afflitte fortune ognor compagna.
Questi campi cosparsi
di ceneri infeconde, e ricoperti
dell'impietrata lava,
che sotto i passi al peregrin risona; 20
dove s'annida e si contorce al sole
la serpe, e dove al noto
cavernoso covil torna il coniglio;
fur liete ville e colti,
e biondeggiar di spiche, e risonaro 25
di muggito d'armenti;
fur giardini e palagi,
agli ozi de' potenti
gradito ospizio; e fur città famose,
che coi torrenti suoi l'altero monte 30
dall'igneia bocca fulminando oppresse
con gli abitanti insieme. Or tutto intorno
una ruina involve,
dove tu siedi, o fior gentile, e quasi
i danni altrui commiserando, al cielo 35
di dolcissimo odor mandi un profumo,

The broom *or the flower of the desert*

And men wanted darkness rather than light.
JOHN, III, 19.

Here on the arid back
of the formidable mountain
Vesuvius the destroyer,
which no other tree gladdens nor flower,
you spread your solitary clusters,
odorous broom,
content with the desert. I saw you also
embellish with your stems the lonely ways
that skirt the city
which was mistress of mortals at one time,
and it seems that of the lost empire
with their aspect taciturn and grave
they serve the traveller as witness and reminder.
Now I see you again upon this land,
lover of sad and world-forsaken places,
and of afflicted fortunes the companion.
These fields strewn
with barren ashes, and covered
with petrified lava,
that rings under the pilgrim's step;
where the snake writhes and nestles in the sun,
and where the rabbit returns
to his familiar burrow;
were happy farms and cultivated fields,
and yellowing ears of grain, and resounded
with the lowing of herds;
were palaces and gardens,
welcome haven to the leisure
of the powerful; and were famous cities
which along with their inhabitants
the haughty mountain exploding
overwhelmed with torrents from its mouth of fire.
Now ruin envelops everything around,
where you dwell, o gentle flower, and almost
commiserating others' woes, you send
to the sky a perfume of the sweetest scent,

che il deserto consola. A queste piagge
 venga colui che d'esaltar con lode
 il nostro stato ha in uso, e vegga quanto
 è il gener nostro in cura 40
 all'amante natura. E la possanza
 qui con giusta misura
 anco estimar potrà dell'uman seme,
 cui la dura nutrice, ov'ei men teme,
 con lieve moto in un momento annulla 45
 in parte, e può con moti
 poco men lievi ancor subitamente
 annichilare in tutto.
 Dipinte in queste rive
 son dell'umana gente 50
le magnifiche sorti e progressive.

Qui mira e qui ti specchia,
 secol superbo e sciocco,
 che il calle insino allora
 dal risorto pensier segnato innanti 55
 abbandonasti, e volti addietro i passi,
 del ritornar ti vanti,
 e procedere il chiami.
 Al tuo pargoleggiar gl'ingegni tutti,
 di cui lor sorte rea padre ti fece, 60
 vanno adulando, ancora
 ch'a ludibrio talora
 t'abbian fra sé. Non io
 con tal vergogna scenderò sotterra;
 ma il disprezzo piuttosto che si serra 65
 di te nel petto mio,
 mostrato avrò quanto si possa aperto:
 ben ch'io sappia che obbligo
 preme chi troppo all'età propria increbbe.
 Di questo mal, che teco 70
 mi fia comune, assai finor mi rido.
 Libertà vai sognando, e servo a un tempo
 vuoi di novo il pensiero,
 sol per cui risorgemmo
 della barbarie in parte, e per cui solo 75
 si cresce in civiltà, che sola in meglio
 guida i pubblici fati.
 Così ti spiacque il vero

which consoles the desert. Let to these slopes
come whoever would exalt
our human state with praise, and let him see
how much mankind is in the care
of loving nature. Here also with just measure
can he gauge the power of human seed,
which the harsh nurse, when he least fears,
with a slight motion, obliterates
in part, and as suddenly can
with motions scarce less slight
annihilate altogether.
Depicted on these shores
are the *grand*,
progressive destinies of man.

Here look and here mirror yourself,
proud and foolish century, you
who abandoned the path which until then
renascent thought had blazed,
and stepping back,
boast of your retreat
and call it an advance.
All the ingenious people of whom
ill fate made you the father
go fawning at your babble,
even though at times they mock you
deep within. Not I
with such shame will descend underground;
rather I will bare as openly as I can
the contempt for you
that is locked in my breast:
though well I know that oblivion
falls on him who displeased too much his age.
This misfortune, which I'll share with you,
is for me cause for laughter at this point.
You go dreaming of freedom, and at the same time
you want to again enslave thought,
through which alone we arose
in part from barbarism, and through which alone
grows civilization, that alone
guides well the public destinies.
So you disliked the truth

dell'aspra sorte e del depresso loco
 che natura ci diè. Per questo il tergo 80
 vigliaccamente rivolgesti al lume
 che il fe' palese: e, fuggitivo, appelli
 vil chi lui segue, e solo
 magnanimo colui
 che sé schernendo o gli altri, astuto o folle, 85
 fin sopra gli astri il mortal grado estolle.

Uom di povero stato e membra inferme
 che sia dell'alma generoso ed alto,
 non chiama sé né stima
 ricco d'or né gagliardo, 90
 e di splendida vita o di valente
 persona infra la gente
 non fa risibil mostra;
 ma sé di forza e di tenor mendico
 lascia parer senza vergogna, e noma 95
 parlando, apertamente, e di sue cose
 fa stima al vero uguale.

Magnanimo animale
 non credo io già, ma stolto,
 quel che nato a perir, nutrito in pene, 100
 dice, a goder son fatto,
 e di fetido orgoglio
 empie le carte, eccelsi fati e nove
 felicità, quali il ciel tutto ignora,
 non pur quest'orbe, promettendo in terra 105
 a popoli che un'onda
 di mar commosso, un fiato
 d'aura maligna, un sotterraneo crollo
 distrugge sì, che avanza
 a gran pena di lor la rimembranza. 110

Nobil natura è quella
 che a sollevar s'ardisce
 gli occhi mortali incontra
 al comun fato, e che con franca lingua,
 nulla al ver detraendo, 115
 confessa il mal che ci fu dato in sorte,
 e il basso stato e frale;
 quella che grande e forte
 mostra sé nel soffrir, né gli odii e l'ire
 fraterne, ancor più gravi 120

of harsh fate and of the lowly position
nature gave us. For this
you cowardly turned your back upon the light
that made it clear: and, fleeing, you call
vile him who follows it, and him alone
magnanimous who,
mocking himself or others, be he cunning or mad,
extols our mortal rank above the stars.

A man of poor estate and feeble limbs,
yet in his soul generous and tall,
neither calls nor deems himself
rich in gold or stalwart,
and makes no ridiculous display
of leading a life of splendor or being valiant;
but is not ashamed of letting himself appear
wanting in strength and wealth,
and, talking, openly says so,
and rates his things according to their worth.
I do not deem magnanimous,
but foolish that creature who,
born to perish, reared in pain,
says, I was made to enjoy myself,
and with fulsome pride fills pages,
promising sublime destinies and new
happiness on earth — such as all of heaven,
let alone this world, knows aught about —
to people whom the wave
of a rough sea, a breath
of noxious air, an underground collapse
destroy so that scarcely
the remembrance of them remains.
Of a noble nature is he who
is bold enough to raise his mortal eyes
against the common fate,
and who, detracting nothing from the truth,
tells frankly of the woe that was allotted to us,
and of our frail, low state;
he who in his suffering
shows himself great and strong,
and, without blaming man for his pain,
does not compound his miseries
with fraternal hatreds and wraths,

d'ogni altro danno, accresce
 alle miserie sue, l'uomo incolpando
 del suo dolor, ma dà la colpa a quella
 che veramente è rea, che de' mortali
 madre è di parto e di voler matrigna. 125
 Costei chiama inimica; e incontro a questa
 congiunta esser pensando,
 siccome è il vero, ed ordinata in pria
 l'umana compagnia,
 tutti fra sé confederati estima 130
 gli uomini, e tutti abbraccia
 con vero amor, porgendo
 valida e pronta ed aspettando aita
 negli alterni perigli e nelle angosce
 della guerra comune. Ed alle offese 135
 dell'uomo armar la destra, e laccio porre
 al vicino ed inciampo,
 stolto crede così qual fora in campo
 cinto d'oste contraria, in sul più vivo
 incalzar degli assalti, 140
 gl'inimici obbliando, acerbe gare
 imprendere con gli amici,
 e sparger fuga e fulminar col brando
 infra i propri guerrieri. 145
 Così fatti pensieri
 quando fien, come fur, palesi al volgo,
 e quell'orror che primo
 contra l'empia natura
 strinse i mortali in social catena,
 fia ricondotto in parte 150
 da verace saper, l'onesto e il retto
 conversar cittadino,
 e giustizia e pietade, altra radice
 avranno allor che non superbe fole,
 ove fondata probità del volgo 155
 così star suole in piede
 quale star può quel ch'ha in error la sede.

 Sovente in queste rive,
 che, desolate, a bruno
 veste il flutto indurato, e par che ondeggi, 160
 seggo la notte; e su la mesta landa
 in purissimo azzurro

more grievous yet than any other ill,
but puts the blame on her
who is really guilty, who is of mortals
mother by birth and stepmother by her wish.
Her he calls enemy: and thinking,
as indeed is the case, that
the society of man is united
and organized against her from the start,
he deems all men confederates
and all of them he embraces with true love,
offering and expecting valiant and prompt help
in the recurring perils and anguishes
of the common struggle. And to arm
the right hand against man,
and to lay a snare or stumbling block
for one's own neighbor,
he believes to be folly no less than if,
in a camp surrounded by the opposing forces,
at the very climax of the assaults,
forgetting the enemy, he were to enter
into bitter contest with his friends,
and, mid his own warriors brandishing the sword,
put them to flight.
When thoughts so fashioned
will be divulged, as they once were,
and when that horror which first
drew mortals into a social bond
against dire nature,
will by true learning
be in part reinstated,
then honest and righteous social intercourse,
justice and pity, shall have a root
other than proud tales,
where people's probity
can stand no more firmly
than something founded upon error.

Often on these desolate shores,
which the hardened flow
drapes darkly, and seems to waver,
I sit at night; and on the somber land
in purest azure

veggo dall'alto fiammeggiar le stelle,
 cui di lontan fa specchio
 il mare, e tutto di scintille in giro 165
 per lo vòto seren brillare il mondo.
 E poi che gli occhi a quelle luci appunto,
 ch'a lor sembrano un punto,
 e sono immense, in guisa
 che un punto a petto a lor son terra e mare 170
 veracemente; a cui
 l'uomo non pur, ma questo
 globo ove l'uomo è nulla,
 sconosciuto è del tutto; e quando miro
 quegli ancor più senz'alcun fin remoti 175
 nodi quasi di stelle,
 ch'a noi paion qual nebbia, a cui non l'uomo
 e non la terra sol, ma tutte in uno,
 del numero infinite e della mole,
 con l'aureo sole insiem, le nostre stelle 180
 o sono ignote, o così paion come
 essi alla terra, un punto
 di luce nebulosa; al pensier mio
 che sembri allor, o prole
 dell'uomo? E rimembrando 185
 il tuo stato quaggiù, di cui fa segno
 il suol ch'io premo; e poi dall'altra parte,
 che te signora e fine
 credi tu data al Tutto, e quante volte
 favoleggiar ti piacque, in questo oscuro 190
 granel di sabbia il qual di terra ha nome,
 per tua cagion, dell'universe cose
 scender gli autori, e conversar sovente
 co' tuoi piacevolmente; e che i derisi
 sogni rinnovellando, ai saggi insulta 195
 fin la presente età, che in conoscenza
 ed in civil costume
 sembra tutte avanzar; qual moto allora,
 mortal prole infelice, o qual pensiero
 verso te finalmente il cor m'assale? 200
 Non so se il riso o la pietà prevale.

Come d'arbor cadendo un picciol pomo;
 cui là nel tardo autunno
 maturità senz'altra forza atterra,

I behold from up high the stars blazing,
which the sea mirrors from afar,
and in sparks all around
through the serene void, the world shining.
And as I fix my eyes upon those lights,
which to them seem a point,
and are immense, so that
compared to them earth and sea are verily
but a point; to which
not only man, but this
globe where man is nothing,
is altogether unknown; and when I look
at those even more endlessly remote
nodes almost of stars
that to us seem like mist, to which not man
and not the stars alone, but all in one, our stars,
infinite in number and in size,
together with the golden sun,
are either unknown, or appear even as
they to earth, a point
of nebulous light; to my thought
what do you seem then, o offspring
of man? And remembering
your state down here,
of which the soil I press is witness,
and you on the other hand, thinking yourself
the chosen lord of All, and how many times
you liked to fable that, on your account,
the authors of universal things descended
on this obscure grain of sand which has the name of earth,
often to converse pleasantly with your kin,
and how, even the present age,
which in knowledge and in civil customs
seems to surpass the rest,
reviving derided dreams, insults the wise,
what feeling then, or what thought,
unhappy progeny of man,
for you at last my heart assails?
I don't know if it is laughter or pity that prevails.

As a small apple falling from a tree,
which late in autumn there
no force other than ripeness sends to earth,

d'un popol di formiche i dolci alberghi, 205
 cavati in molle gleba
 con gran lavoro, e l'opre
 e le ricchezze ch' adunate a prova
 con lungo affaticar l'assidua gente
 avea provvidamente al tempo estivo, 210
 schiaccia, diserta e copre
 in un punto; così d'alto piombando,
 dall'utero tonante
 scagliata al ciel profondo,
 di ceneri e di pomici e di sassi 215
 notte e ruina, infusa
 di bollenti ruscelli,
 o pel montano fianco
 furiosa tra l'erba
 di liquefatti massi 220
 e di metalli e d'infocata arena
 scendendo immensa piena,
 le cittadi che il mar là su l'estremo
 lido aspergea, confuse
 e infranse e ricoperse 225
 in pochi istanti: onde su quelle or pasce
 la capra, e città nove
 sorgon dall'altra banda, a cui sgabello
 son le sepolte, e le prostrate mura
 l'arduo monte al suo piè quasi calpesta. 230
 Non ha natura al seme
 dell'uom più stima o cura
 che alla formica: e se più rara in quello
 che nell'altra è la strage,
 non avvien ciò d'altronde 235
 fuor che l'uom sue prosapie ha men feconde.

Ben mille ed ottocento
 anni varcàr poi che spariro, oppressi
 dall'igneia forza, i popolati seggi,
 e il villanello intento 240
 ai vigneti, che a stento in questi campi
 nutre la morta zolla e incenerita,
 ancor leva lo sguardo
 sospettoso alla vetta
 fatal, che nulla mai fatta più mite 245
 ancor siede tremenda, ancor minaccia

crushes, demolishes and covers
in one swoop, of a population of ants the sweet abodes,
burrowed with great labor
in the moist earth, and the works
and riches which the assiduous colony
during the summer had eagerly garnered with long toil,
so plummeting from above,
hurled to the deep sky
from the thundering womb,
a night and ruin of ashes,
of pumice and of stones, mixed
with boiling streams,
or down the mountain flank
an immense flood
of molten boulders
and of metals and of fiery sand,
descending furious through the grass,
confounded and smashed and covered up
in a few moments the cities that the sea bathed
on the shore's edge: where on them now
grazes the goat, and on the other side
new cities rise, for which
the buried ones are as a sill,
and the arduous mountain almost tramples
the walls lying prostrate at its feet.
Nature has for man's seed
no more respect or care
than for the ant: and if slaughter
is rarer for one than for the other,
it happens only because
man's breed is less fecund.

Full eighteen-hundred years
have gone by since, overpowered
by the igneous force, the populated places disappeared,
and the peasant intent
upon the vineyards, which in these fields
the dead and cindered sod will barely nourish,
still raises a suspicious glance
at the fatal summit,
which, never any milder made,
still sits tremendous, still threatens

a lui strage ed ai figli ed agli averi
 lor poverelli. E spesso
 il meschino in sul tetto
 dell'ostel villereccio, alla vagante 250
 aura giacendo tutta notte insonne,
 e balzando più volte, esplora il corso
 del temuto bollor, che si riversa
 dall'inesausto grembo
 su l'arenoso dorso, a cui riluce 255
 di Capri la marina
 e di Napoli il porto e Mergellina.
 E se appressar lo vede, o se nel cupo
 del domestico pozzo ode mai l'acqua
 fervendo gorgogliar, desta i figliuoli, 260
 desta la moglie in fretta, e via, con quanto
 di lor cose rapir posson, fuggendo,
 vede lontan l'usato
 suo nido, e il picciol campo,
 che gli fu dalla fame unico schermo, 265
 preda al flutto rovente,
 che crepitando giunge, e inesorato
 durabilmente sovra quei si spiega.
 Torna al celeste raggio
 dopo l'antica obblivion l'estinta 270
 Pompei, come sepolto
 scheletro, cui di terra
 avarizia o pietà rende all'aperto;
 e dal deserto foro
 diritto infra le file 275
 dei mozzi colonnati il peregrino
 lunge contempla il bipartito giogo
 e la cresta fumante,
 che alla sparsa ruina ancor minaccia.
 E nell'orror della secreta notte 280
 per li vacui teatri,
 per li templi deformi e per le rotte
 case, ove i parti il pipistrello asconde,
 come sinistra face
 che per vòti palagi atra s'aggiri, 285
 corre il baglior della funerea lava,
 che di lontan per l'ombra
 rosseggia e i lochi intorno intorno tinge.
 Così, dell'uomo ignara e dell'etadi

him and his children and their poor little belongings
with destruction. And often
the wretch on the roof
of his rustic home, lying
sleepless all nightlong in the wayward wind,
with many a start, observes the course
of the feared boiling, which overflows
from the unexhausted womb
onto the gritty ridge, whose glow is cast
on Capri's shores,
on Naples' port and Mergellina.
And if he sees it approaching, or if in the darkness
of his house's well he ever hears the seething
water gurgle, he wakes his children,
he wakes his wife in haste, and running away,
with as many of their things as they can snatch,
he sees from far away his familiar
nest, and the small field
which was from hunger his sole shield,
prey to the burning wave,
which crackling arrives, and permanently
spreads on them its inexorable self.
After ancient oblivion extinct Pompeii
returns to the celestial ray,
like a buried skeleton, which,
from underground,
avarice or pity give back to the open air;
and, from the deserted forum
standing among the rows
of lopped-off colonnades, the pilgrim
contemplates far away the two-humped range
and the smoking crest,
which menaces still the scattered ruins.
And in the horror of the secret night
through the empty theaters,
the deformed temples and the broken
houses, where the bat hides its brood,
like a sinister torch
that lurid wanders through the deserted halls,
runs the glow of the funereal lava,
which reddens through the shadows
from afar and tinges the places roundabout.
So, ignoring man and the ages

ch'ei chiama antiche, e del seguir che fanno 290
dopo gli avi i nepoti,
sta natura ognor verde, anzi procede
per sì lungo cammino
che sembra star. Caggiono i regni intanto,
passan genti e linguaggi: ella nol vede: 295
e l'uom d'eternità s'arroga il vanto.

E tu, lenta ginestra,
che di selve odorate
queste campagne dispogliate adorni,
anche tu presto alla crudel possanza 300
soccomberai del sotterraneo foco,
che ritornando al loco
già noto, stenderà l'avarò lembo
su tue molli foreste. E piegherai
sotto il fascio mortal non renitente 305
il tuo capo innocente:
ma non piegato insino allora indarno
codardamente supplicando innanzi
al futuro oppressor; ma non eretto
con forsennato orgoglio inver le stelle, 310
né sul deserto, dove
e la sede e i natali
non per voler ma per fortuna avesti;
ma più saggia, ma tanto
meno inferma dell'uom, quanto le frali 315
tue stirpi non credesti
o dal fato o da te fatte immortali.

he calls ancient, and the succession
of grandchild on grandparent,
nature stays ever green, or rather she proceeds
over such a long path
that she seems to stand still. Meanwhile kingdoms fall,
languages and people pass: she sees not:
and man arrogates to himself vaunt of eternity.

And you, lithe broom,
that with odorous thickets
adorn these despoiled fields,
you too soon shall succumb to
the cruel might of the subterranean fire,
which, returning to the places
that it knows, will spread its greedy hem
on your pliant shrubs. And unrenitent
you shall bow your innocent head
under the mortal rod:
but not till then bowed in vain
in cowardly supplication before
the future oppressor; but not erect
with mindless pride toward the stars,
or on this desert, where
not by your own will but by chance
you had your home and birth,
but so much wiser and so much
less weak than man, for not believing
that your frail origins
either by fate or by you were made immortal.

